Italian, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one word at a time

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This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they are written.

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Preface

This book teaches Italian one word at a time, and it teaches each word by taking it apart — traced back to its root (usually Latin), then forward to the English cousins you already own, so nothing here is a fresh thing to memorise. It is written for someone starting from zero, whose only shared language is English. *grazie* ("thanks") turns out to be English *grace*; *giorno* ("day") is the *journ-* of *journal* and *journey*; and *ciao*, the most famous "hello" in the world, once meant "I am your slave."

Italian is the closest living child of Latin, so its words often wear their roots most plainly of the Romance languages. Where a sister language (Spanish or French, the other daughters of Latin) makes the contrast vivid, the book shows it — every form supplied in full, so no prior knowledge of them is assumed; a reader who happens to know one simply nods along.

How to use this book

Every numbered section is one word, or one small phrase, and takes a few minutes — the length of a queue, an errand, or the walk to the bus. Read them in order the first time through: each section stands on the ones before it, and nothing is used before it has been taught. After that the book becomes reference, and you can open it anywhere.

Say the Italian out loud wherever you can. The prompts under *Your turn* are written to be spoken, and saying a word is most of what makes it stay. The questions under *Before you move on* carry their own answers in brackets: cover them, answer from memory, then look.

Nothing here is gated behind pronunciation. Each lesson names the one or two sounds its own word needs, exactly where they are needed. The whole system is gathered in a reference at the back of the book — somewhere to look things up when you are curious, never a chapter to sit through first.

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Chapter 1

Greetings

Modes: **voice** (8) **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** first 6 of 9 lessons.

The Italian greetings, built from their pieces — a word for "good," the day-parts, the article that carries gender, and the most famous "hello" in the world. Each word is taken apart to its root and its English cousins.

1.1 *ciao* — "hi," and the word that means "I am your slave"

Sounds you'll need

CHOW — *ci* before a vowel is the *ch* of *church*, and *-ao* is one gliding syllable, like the English *ciao* you may already have heard.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ciao began as the Venetian greeting *s-ciào (vostro)* — "[I am your] slave / servant," a humble "at your service." That *s-ciào* is Venetian for *schiavo* ("slave") ← Medieval Latin *sclavus*. The very same word is English **slave** — and, astonishingly, **Slav**: medieval slaves were so often Slavic captives that the ethnic name *became* the word for "slave" across Europe. So every casual *ciao* is a fossil of "I am your servant," carrying the buried history of a whole people.

Why it's said this way

ciao is **informal**, and works both coming and going ("hi" and "bye") — for friends, family, peers. To someone you'd show respect, or on a first

meeting, you reach instead for *buongiorno*, built over the next lessons. (Doubled, *ciao ciao*, it's a breezy "bye-bye.")

1.2 *buono* / *buon* — "good"

Sounds you'll need

buono = *BWOH-no*; the *uo* is a glide. Before a masculine noun it clips to **buon** (*bwon*) — *buon giorno*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

buono ("good") ← Latin *bonus* → English **bon**us, **bon**anza, **bon**bon, and (through French) **boun**ty. Spanish, another daughter of Latin, made the same *bonus* into *bueno*; Italian kept it closer, *buono*.

Grammar Lens

buono **agrees** with its noun in gender and number — *buono* (m.), *buona* (f.), *buoni* / *buone* (pl.). This gender-agreement of adjectives is Latin's legacy across the Romance family. Before a masculine noun *buono* drops its *-o* to *buon*: you'll see it in *buon giorno*.

1.3 *il* / *la* / *lo* — "the," and the gender it carries

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

il and **lo** (masculine "the") and **la** (feminine) ← Latin *ille* / *illa* ("that one"), the pointing word worn down to "the." The same *ille/illa* gave Spanish *el/la* and French *le/la* — and also Italian **lui/lei** ("he/she"). (English "the" is Germanic, unrelated.)

Grammar Lens

Every Italian noun is masculine or feminine — Latin's three genders (the neuter folded mostly into the masculine) collapsed to two. Learn each noun *with* its article. Italian has *two* masculine "the"s: **lo** before tricky clusters (*lo studente*, *lo zio*) and **il** everywhere else (*il giorno*); feminine is always *la*. Don't drill the rule — just meet *il* at the

first noun, next.

1.4 *giorno* — "day," and the road to English *journey*

Sounds you'll need

gi = the *j* of *jam*; *gior-no* = *JOR-no*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

il giorno (masc.) ← Latin *diurnum* ("daytime"), from *dies* ("day"). That detour through *diurnum* is why *giorno* looks nothing like Latin *dies*: cousins are **jour**nal, ad**journ**, so**journ**, and **journ**ey (a *day's* travel) — all from the same *diurnum* — plus **di**urnal and **di**ary straight from *dies*. Italian *giorno* and French *jour* are near-twins here; Spanish, taking *dies* directly, got the very different *día*.

Grammar Lens

giorno is **masculine** (*il giorno*). Plural *i giorni* — Italian marks the plural by changing the final vowel (*-o* → *-i*), not by adding *-s*.

1.5 *buongiorno* — "good day," assembled

buon ("good") + *giorno* ("day") = **buongiorno**, "good day," one word — the polite, all-purpose daytime hello.

Why it's said this way

Where the casual *ciao* says "I'm your servant," *buongiorno* simply wishes you a good day — and it is the **safe, respectful** choice with anyone: shopkeepers, strangers, elders. Used through the day until late afternoon, when it gives way to *buonasera*.

1.6 *sera* — "evening," and *buonasera*

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la sera (fem.) ← Latin *sera* ("late [hour]"), from *serus*, "late." English cousin: the rare *serotine* (a bat of the *late* evening). **buonasera** = *buona* + *sera*, "good evening" — *buona* in its feminine form, because *sera* is feminine.

1.7 *notte* — "night," and the *-ct-* → *-tt-* rule

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la notte (fem.) ← Latin *noctem* (*noct-*) → **noct**urnal, equi**nox**. The change is a *rule*: Latin *-ct-* became Italian **-tt-** (*no<u>tt</u>e*), where Spanish softened it to *-ch-* (*noche*) and French to *-it-* (*nuit*).

Latin	Italian	Spanish	French	English
noctem	no*tt*e	no*ch*e	nu*it*	night
lactem	la*tt*e	le*ch*e	la*it*	(lact-)
factum	fa*tt*o	he*ch*o	fa*it*	fact

buonanotte = *buona* + *notte*, "good night" — the farewell for bed (not an evening hello; that's *buonasera*).

1.8 *grazie* — "thank you," from *grace*

Sounds you'll need

GRAH-tsyeh — **z** in Italian is *ts*; the final *-e* is sounded (two syllables in *-zie*).

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

grazie ("thanks") ← Latin *gratiæ*, plural of *gratia* ("favour, thanks, grace"). It is the *same gratia* behind English **grace**, **grat**itude, **grat**eful, **grat**is ("free"), con**grat**ulate, and in**grat**iate. So *grazie* literally offers someone *grace*. (Reply: *prego*, "you're welcome" — literally "I pray [it's nothing]."')

1.9 The day of greetings

Italian	English
ciao	hi / bye (informal)
buongiorno	good day
buonasera	good evening
buonanotte	good night
grazie	thank you

Every piece from a Latin root: *ciao* (*sclavus*, "slave"), *buono* (*bonus*), *giorno* (*diurnum*), *notte* (*noctem*, via the *-ct-*→*-tt-* rule), *grazie* (*gratia*, "grace"). Next chapter: introducing yourself — *mi chiamo…* ("my name is…") — and Italian's *tu* vs. *Lei* (familiar / formal "you").

Chapter 2

How Are You?

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (8) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 8 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can ask an Italian how they are, formally or informally, answer for myself, and hand the question back.
>
> *The full Come stai? exchange run both ways — sta and Lei for respect, stai and tu for a friend — answered with sto bene or così così and closed with grazie / prego.*

2.1 prego — "you're welcome," literally "I pray"

The *grazie* lesson already promised you this word. Someone says **grazie**; you reply **prego**. Like German *bitte*, it's a small word that does several jobs — and it comes straight from **praying**.

Sounds you'll need

- `hard-g-before-o` — **prego** = *PREH-go* with a **hard** g. (Italian g is soft only before *e/i*; here the g is followed by *o*, so it stays hard.)

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

prego is "I pray" — the *io* ("I") form of **pregare**, "to pray, to beg," from Latin **precārī**. When you answer *grazie* with *prego*, you're softly saying *"I pray (it was nothing) / please, don't mention it."*
That root **prec-** ("pray, entreat") gives English a surprising family:

- **pray**, **prayer** — the direct line.

- **precarious** — literally "held by *prayer*," i.e. depending on someone's goodwill, therefore unstable.
- **deprecate** ("pray *away*, ward off") and **imprecation** ("a prayer *against* — a curse").

Like German **bitte**, *prego* stretches across situations, all of them a form of "I pray you":

you say *prego* when...	**it means**
answering *grazie*	**you're welcome**
offering a seat / letting someone pass	**please, go ahead / after you**
handing something over	**here you are**
you didn't catch it	**sorry, come again?**

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "grazie" … "prego" — the full exchange
- "prego" then English "pray, precarious" — one family

Before you move on

What verb is *prego* the "I" form of? (*pregare*, "to pray.") What English word means "held by prayer" and so "unstable"? (*Precarious.*) Which German word does *prego* behave like? (*bitte* — one word, many courtesies.) Next: **come**, "how."

2.2 come — "how," the third *quomodo* cousin

To ask *how are you?* you need "how." In Italian it's **come** — and if you've seen the Spanish or French tracks, you already know its family.

Sounds you'll need

- `soft-c` — **come** = *KOH-meh*. Here *c* is before *o*, so it's a **hard** *k* (Italian *c* only softens to *ch* before *e/i*). Final *-e* is sounded: *KOH-meh*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

come = "how / like / as." Root: Latin **quōmodo**, "in what manner" — two words (*quō* "in what way" + *modo* "manner") fused and worn down. It is the **same source** as:

- Spanish **cómo** ("how")
- French **comment** ("how")
- and, doubling as "like/as," it matches Spanish **como** and French **comme**.

So one Latin *quōmodo* became the "how" word in all three Romance sisters. The *modo* piece ("manner, measure") also lives in English **mode**, **mod**el, **mod**erate — all about the *way* something is done.
Note Italian *come* covers **both** jobs at once, and the written accent tells them apart only by context, not spelling: *Come stai?* ("**How** are you?") vs *bianco come la neve* ("white **as** snow").

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "come" — *KOH-meh*
- come / cómo / comment — the three *quomodo* siblings
- English *mode, model* share the *modo* piece

Before you move on

What Latin word gives *come*, and which Spanish and French words are its siblings? (*quōmodo* → *cómo*, *comment*.) What two jobs does *come* do? ("How?" and "like/as.") Next: the verb it pairs with — **stare**.

2.3 stare — "to be," the standing kind (Spanish's estar, undressed)

Like Spanish, Italian has **two** verbs for "to be" — **essere** (identity) and **stare** (state). "How are you?" runs on **stare**. Spanish's *estar* is this very verb, with a front *e* added on.

Sounds you'll need

- `st-clean` — Italian, unlike Spanish, is happy to start a word with *st-*: no propping *e*. **stare** = *STAH-reh*, clean *st*, final *-e* sounded.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

stare comes straight from Latin **stāre**, *"to stand."* Spanish grew the same verb into **estar** (with a propping *e-*); Italian kept it bare as **stare**. Same Latin root, same job: the *temporary state* be-verb — how you *stand* right now.
That **stā-** root stands behind a wall of English words: **stay**, **stand**, **state**, **status**, **stable**, **station**, **stance**, **e-state**, **con-stant**, **circum-stance**. So *Come stai?* is, at the root, **"how do you stand?"** — the very same picture as Spanish *¿Cómo estás?*.

Grammar Lens: essere vs stare, and the two forms you need

verb	from	job
essere	Latin *esse*	identity — *sono Marco*, "I am Marco"
stare	Latin *stāre*	state / how you are — *sto bene*, "I'm well"

For this chapter, just two forms of *stare*:

- **stai** — "you are" (informal, *tu*)
- **sta** — "you are" (formal, *Lei*) / "he/she is"

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "stare" — *STAH-reh*, clean *st*
- "stai" … "sta" — the two forms you'll ask with
- Italian *stare* = Spanish *estar*, same Latin *stāre* "to stand"

Before you move on

What Latin verb is *stare*, and which Spanish verb is its twin? ("To stand," *stāre* — Spanish *estar*.) Which Italian be-verb is for how you feel — *essere* or *stare*? (*stare*.) Next: ask it — **Come stai?**

2.4 Come stai? — "how are you?"

Both pieces are ready: **come** ("how") and **stare / stai** ("to be," from *stand*). Assemble Italian's everyday question for a friend.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

> **Come stai?** = "How are you?" (informal) literally: **"How do you stand?"**

- **come** = "how"
- **stai** = "you are / stand," the *tu* form of *stare*

The subject **tu** ("you") is already carried by **stai**, so Italian normally leaves it unspoken. Say **Come stai?**, not *Come tu stai?*, unless you need to stress "you." This is the same pro-drop habit you will use in later verb lessons.
An everyday answer reuses the same verb:

> **Come stai? — Sto bene, grazie.** "How are you? — I'm well, thanks."

Sto means "I am / stand." The pair **stai / sto** lets the ending do the pronoun's work: "you" in *-ai*, "I" in *-o*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "Come stai?" — informal, for a friend
- "Sto bene, grazie."
- the two-part exchange — "Come stai? — Sto bene."

Twice through: "Come stai? — Sto bene, grazie."

Before you move on

Come stai? literally asks what? ("How do you **stand**?") Which word means "how"? (**Come**.) Which form answers "I am"? (**Sto**.) Give the whole exchange: **Come stai? — Sto bene, grazie.** Next: formal speech and the "go" version.

2.5 Come sta? — the formal question

You can ask a friend **Come stai?** Change one ending when you speak to a stranger or elder.

Grammar Lens: stai and sta

Come sta? = "How are you?" (formal)

Italian uses **Lei** — literally "she," often capitalized — as a polite "you." Its verb therefore uses the third-person form **sta**, not informal **stai**:

listener	question
a friend (*tu*)	**Come stai?**
a stranger or elder (*Lei*)	**Come sta?**

The politeness pattern has cousins in Spanish *usted* and German *Sie*, but you only need one Italian contrast here: **stai** for a friend, **sta** for formal respect.
An answer can return the formal pronoun:

Bene, grazie. E Lei? — "Well, thank you. And you?"

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- to a friend — "Come stai?"

- to a stranger — "Come sta?"
- "Bene, grazie. E Lei?"

Twice through: "Stai — friend. Sta — formal."

Before you move on

Which ending marks a friend? (**-i: stai**.) Which form is formal? (**Sta**.) What polite pronoun can follow *e*, "and"? (**Lei**.) Next: keep the meaning but switch the picture from "stand" to "go."

2.6 Come va? — "how is it going?"

Come stai? pictures wellbeing as standing. Italian also has the same "going" picture as English.

Come va? = "How's it going?"

Va comes from **andare**, "to go." Unlike *stai / sta*, this question does not force you to choose an informal or formal ending, so it is useful in either setting.

Grammar Lens: standing and going

- **Come stai?** — "How do you **stand**?"
- **Come va?** — "How does it **go**?"

Spanish also uses the "stand" picture in *¿cómo estás?*; French and German use a "go" picture. Italian keeps **both**, which makes it a bridge between them. The comparison is only a memory aid: in Italian, simply connect **stai** with *stare* and **va** with *andare*.
You will learn all six forms of *andare* much later. For now, **va** is one ready-made piece inside this question.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the standing question — "Come stai?"

- the going question — "Come va?"
- "Come va? — Bene, grazie."

Twice through: "Come stai? — Come va?"

Before you move on

Which question uses "stand"? (**Come stai?**) Which uses "go"? (**Come va?**) What infinitive owns **va**? (**Andare**.) Must *Come va?* choose between *tu* and *Lei*? (**No**.) Next: answer with the original Italian "so-so."

2.7 così così — the original "so-so"

English "so-so" is a **loan translation of the Italian** *così così*. Someone asks *Come stai?*; you're middling; you wobble a hand and say *così così* — "thus and thus," this way and that.

Sounds you'll need

- `soft-c` — **così** = *koh-ZEE*: the *c* is before *o* (hard *k*), and the single *s* between vowels is **voiced**, a *z* sound: *koh-**ZEE***. Stress the end (that's what the accent on *ì* marks).

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

così = "thus, so, in this way," from Latin **(ec)cum sīc**, "(behold) so." Doubled — *così così* — it means "**so** and **so**," neither up nor down: a verbal shrug.
The core piece **sīc** ("thus, so") is one you already write in English:

- **sic** — the *[sic]* you put after a quoted mistake means "**thus** it was written."
- It's also the Latin behind Spanish/French/Italian **sì / si / sì** ("yes" — "it is *so*"), and the *-si* inside French **ain-si** ("thus").

So *così così* is literally **"so, so"** — and English simply borrowed the shrug whole.

Grammar Lens: your answer ladder for *Come stai?*

answer	sense
(Molto) bene, grazie	(very) well, thanks
Così così	so-so
Non c'è male	"not bad" (lit. "there isn't bad")

The cross-track shrug set, now five deep: Italian **così così** ("so, so"), French **comme ci comme ça** ("like this, like that"), Spanish **más o menos** ("more or less"), German **es geht** ("it goes").

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "così così" — *koh-ZEE koh-ZEE*, with a hand-wobble
- answer "Come stai?" three ways — "Bene" / "Così così" / "Non c'è male"
- "sic" in English — "thus" — the same *sīc*

Before you move on

What does *così così* literally mean? ("Thus, thus / so, so.") What Latin word for "so" is inside it, and where do you still write it in English? (*sīc* → *[sic]*.) English "so-so" came from — which language? (Italian *così così*.) Next: put the exchange together.

2.8 Practice — "Come stai?", start to finish

No new words. This chapter's atoms — *prego, come, stare, come stai?, così così* — assemble into a real exchange, formal and informal. It picks up from the Chapter 1 greetings.

The exchange

Formal (a stranger, an elder — *Lei*):

— Buongiorno. **Come sta?** — **Bene, grazie.** E Lei? — **Così così.** — [after a small favour] — Grazie! — **Prego.**

Informal (a friend — *tu*):

— Ciao! **Come stai?** — **Sto bene, e tu?** — Non c'è male.

The glue is **e Lei? / e tu?** — "and you?" (*e* = "and," Latin *et*) — the Italian twin of Spanish *¿y usted?* and French *et toi?*.

What you've built this chapter

- **prego** — you're welcome / please (← *pregare*, "to pray"; English *precarious*).
- **come** — how (← *quōmodo*; sibling of *cómo* / *comment*).
- **stare** — "to be" from *stand* (= Spanish *estar*); vs *essere* (identity).
- **Come stai? / sta? / va?** — informal, formal, and the "how's it going?" form (*va* ← *andare*, "to go").
- **così così** — so-so (English "so-so" borrowed it whole).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the full *formal* exchange, both voices
- the same *informally* — *sta* → *stai*, *Lei* → *tu*
- all three questions — Come stai? / Come sta? / Come va?

Twice through: "Come stai? — Sto bene, grazie, e tu?" until it's reflex.

Before you move on

Which verb carries *Come stai?*, and what does it literally ask? (*stare*, "to stand" — "how do you stand?") What does *prego* answer, and from what root? (*grazie*; ← *pregare*, "to pray.") Italian can ask "how are you" two ways — which verbs? (*stare*, stand; *andare* → *va*, go.) Next chapter: **introducing yourself** — mi chiamo, come ti chiami.

Chapter 3

Introducing Yourself

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can give my name in Italian, ask for someone else's, and say that it is a pleasure.
>
> *A whole first meeting: ciao, mi chiamo …, Come ti chiami? in the informal and Come si chiama? in the formal, and piacere to close it.*

3.1 io — "I," the pronoun Italian loves to leave out

Before you introduce yourself, meet **io** — "I." It's a small word with a famous English cousin, and a surprising habit: Italian usually **drops it.**

Sounds you'll need

- `io-glide` — **io** = *EE-oh*, two quick vowels gliding together, stress the first: *EE-oh*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

io = "I," worn down from Latin **ego** — which English borrowed *whole*:

- **ego** — literally Latin "I" (your sense of self).
- **egoist**, **egotist**, **egocentric** — all built on that "I."
- Its Romance siblings: Spanish **yo**, Portuguese **eu**, French **je** — every one a child of *ego*.

Grammar Lens: the dropped subject (pro-drop)

Here's the Italian habit worth learning now: **the verb ending already tells you who's speaking, so the pronoun is usually left out.** *Sto bene* ("I'm well") needs no *io* — the *-o* of *sto* is "I." You add **io** only for **emphasis** or **contrast**:

> *Io* sto bene — e tu? — "*I'm* fine — and you?"

Spanish (*yo*) and Portuguese (*eu*) do exactly the same. English can't: it must say "I" every time. So learning Italian means learning to *trust the verb ending* and let the pronoun go.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "io" — *EE-oh*
- "io" then English "ego, egoist" — the same Latin "I"
- "Sto bene" with no *io* — the ending carries the "I"

Before you move on

What Latin word is *io* from, and what English words share it? (*Ego* — ego, egoist.) Why does Italian usually drop *io*? (The verb ending already says who.) When do you keep it? (For emphasis/contrast.) Next: use it to introduce yourself — **mi chiamo**.

3.2 mi chiamo — "I call myself"

Like Spanish and French, Italian doesn't say "my name is." It says **"I call myself"** — **mi chiamo**. Same reflexive trick, same *clāmāre* root as Spanish *me llamo*.

Sounds you'll need

- `ch-hard-k` — Italian **ch** is a **hard k** (the opposite of English!): so **chiamo** = *KYAH-moh*, not "chee-." (Italian softens *c* to *ch*-sound only before *e/i*; the *h* in *chi* is there precisely to keep it

hard.)

- **mi chiamo** = *mee KYAH-moh.*

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

mi chiamo = **mi** ("myself") + **chiamo** ("I call") → **"I call myself."**
Then the name: *Mi chiamo Marco* — "I call myself Marco."
The verb is **chiamarsi** ("to call oneself"), from Latin **clāmāre**, *"to cry out, to call."* That root shouts through English:

- **claim**, **exclaim**, **proclaim**, **acclaim**, **clamor** — all "calling out."
- Its Romance siblings all name people the same way: Spanish **llamarse** (*me llamo*), Portuguese **chamar-se** (*me chamo*) — the *cl-* softening to *ll-* (Spanish) or *ch-* (Italian/Portuguese). One Latin "call," three naming verbs.

Grammar Lens: the reflexive, and the dropping of *io*

chiamo alone is "I call [someone else]"; **mi** chiamo is "I call **myself**" — **reflexive**, the action looping back on you. The pronoun changes with the person: **mi** chiamo (I) → **ti** chiami (you) → **si** chiama (he/she/formal). And notice: no *io* — the *-o* ending already says "I." (You met that pro-drop last lesson.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "mi chiamo" — *mee KYAH-moh*, hard *k* in *chiamo*
- "Mi chiamo …" with your own name
- "chiamo" then English "claim, exclaim, clamor" — the *clāmāre* family

Before you move on

What does *mi chiamo* literally mean? ("I call myself.") What Latin verb is *chiamarsi* from, and its English cousins? (*clāmāre* — claim,

exclaim, clamor.) How is Italian *ch* pronounced? (A hard *k*.) Next: ask it back — **Come ti chiami?**

3.3 Come ti chiami? — "what's your name?"

You have both pieces: **come** ("how," from your how-are-you chapter) and **chiamarsi** ("to call oneself"). Like Spanish and French, Italian asks the name with **"how"**, not "what": *how do you call yourself?*

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Come ti chiami? = "What's your name?" (informal) literally: **"How do you call yourself?"**

- **come** = "how" (← *quōmodo*; you met it in *Come stai?*).
- **ti** = "yourself" (the reflexive, matching *mi* → *ti*).
- **chiami** = "you call" (the *tu* form of *chiamarsi*).

Two registers — the same *tu* / *Lei* split you learned in Chapter 2:

register	question
informal (*tu*)	**Come ti chiami?**
formal (*Lei*)	**Come si chiama?**

Only the reflexive pronoun and the ending move: *ti chiami* → *si chiama* — the identical pattern to *mi chiamo* → *si chiama*. The whole exchange:

— Come ti chiami? — Mi chiamo Marco. E tu?

Note Italian asks the name with *come* ("how"), exactly like Spanish *¿cómo se llama?* and French *comment vous appelez-vous?* — the name is a matter of *how* you're called, not *what* you are.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "Come ti chiami?" — informal, for a peer

- "Come si chiama?" — formal, for a stranger (Lei)
- the whole swap — "Come ti chiami? — Mi chiamo … E tu?"

Before you move on

What does *Come ti chiami?* literally ask? ("How do you call yourself?") What changes for the formal *Lei* version? (*ti chiami* → *si chiama.*) Which "how" word is it built on? (*come* ← *quōmodo.*) Next: the reply when you meet — **piacere**.

3.4 piacere — "pleased to meet you," i.e. "a pleasure"

Names exchanged, you close the introduction with one warm word: **piacere** — literally *"a pleasure."* It's the twin of a word you'd say in Portuguese, and it's pure Latin *please*.

Sounds you'll need

- `soft-c` — **piacere** = *pya-**CHEH**-reh*: here *c* is before *e*, so it's soft (*ch*), and the *ia* glides: *pya-CHE-re*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

piacere = "a pleasure" (and, as a verb, "to please"), from Latin **placēre**, *"to please, to be pleasing."* Said on meeting someone, it's short for *"[it's] a pleasure [to meet you]."*
That **placēre** root is thoroughly at home in English:

- **please**, **pleasure**, **pleasant** — the direct line.
- **complacent** ("pleased *with* oneself"), **complaisant**, **placid** (pleased → calm).

And across the family, "pleased to meet you" is built from the *same* idea nearly everywhere:

- Portuguese **prazer** (← *placēre* too — its twin).
- French **enchanté** (a different image — "enchanted").

- Spanish **mucho gusto** ("much pleasure," but from *gustus*, "taste" — a different Latin root).

Grammar Lens: a one-word courtesy

Piacere stands alone — you just say it, with a small nod, as you shake hands. For a touch more you can say *molto piacere* ("much pleasure") or *piacere di conoscerti* ("pleasure to know you").

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "piacere" — *pya-CHEH-reh*
- "piacere" then English "please, pleasure, placid" — the *placēre* root
- Italian *piacere* and Portuguese *prazer* — twins from *placēre*

Before you move on

What does *piacere* literally mean, and from what? ("A pleasure," ← *placēre* "to please.") Its English cousins? (Please, pleasure, placid, complacent.) Which Portuguese word is its twin? (*Prazer.*) Next: put the whole introduction together.

3.5 Practice — introducing yourself in Italian

No new words. *io, mi chiamo, come ti chiami, piacere* now assemble into a real first meeting — run it formally and informally until the register swap is automatic. This slots between your greetings (Ch. 1–2) and farewells (Ch. 4).

The exchange

Informal (a peer):

> — Ciao! **Come ti chiami?** — **Mi chiamo** Marco. E tu? — Giulia. **Piacere!** — Piacere!

Formal (a stranger — *Lei*):

— Buongiorno. **Come si chiama?** — Mi chiamo Marco Rossi.
E Lei? — Rossi. **Molto piacere.**

What you've built this chapter

- **io** — "I" (← *ego*), usually **dropped** — the verb ending carries it.
- **mi chiamo** — "I call myself" (*chiamarsi* ← *clāmāre*, "call out"; kin of Spanish *me llamo*, Portuguese *me chamo*).
- **Come ti chiami? / Come si chiama?** — "how do you call yourself?", informal / formal.
- **piacere** — "a pleasure" (← *placēre*; twin of Portuguese *prazer*).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the full informal meeting, both voices
- the same formally — *ti chiami* → *si chiama*, *tu* → *Lei*
- chain it all — greet, name, ask, how-are-you, goodbye: "Ciao! Mi chiamo … Come ti chiami? … Come stai? … A domani!"

Twice through: Run a whole first meeting start to finish.

Before you move on

Why does Italian usually drop *io*? (The verb ending says who.) What does *mi chiamo* literally mean, and its root? ("I call myself"; *clāmāre*.) What does *piacere* mean? ("A pleasure.") Italian now runs greet → introduce → how-are-you → goodbye, end to end.

Chapter 4

Farewells

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can close an Italian conversation and pick the goodbye that matches when I will next see the person.
>
> *Open with ciao, ask Come stai?, then choose the exit — a più tardi within the hour, a domani for tomorrow, a presto for soon, arrivederci for until-we-meet-again.*

4.1 arrivederci — "goodbye," i.e. "until we meet again"

You can open a conversation in Italian and ask how someone is. Now, close it. The standard goodbye is **arrivederci** — and, like its French and German cousins, it doesn't say "goodbye" at all. It says **"until we see each other again."**

Sounds you'll need

- **arrivederci** = *ar-ree-veh-**DER**-chee*: a tapped double *r*, and the final *-ci* is soft (*chee*, Italian *c* before *i*). Stress the *-der-*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Break it into four pieces you can almost read straight off:

- **a** = "to / until" (Latin *ad*).
- **ri-** = "again" (Latin *re-* — as in English *re*-do, *re*-view).

- **vedere** = "to see" (Latin *vidēre* → English **video**, **vision**, **evident**, **provide**).
- **-ci** = "us / each other."

Glued: *a-(ri)-vedere-ci* → **"to our seeing-one-another-again."** You don't say farewell; you promise the next meeting.
The whole family says the same thing
This "until re-seeing" idea is shared right across the languages you're learning — a lovely thing to notice:

language	goodbye	literally
Italian	*arrivederci*	"to our re-seeing"
French	*au revoir*	"to the re-seeing" (*re* + *voir*, see)
German	*auf Wiedersehen*	"on again-seeing" (*wieder* + *sehen*)

Three languages, one gesture: part by pointing at the reunion, not the parting. (Italian keeps a heavier, final "to God" goodbye too — **addio**, *a Dio* — the exact twin of Spanish *adiós*; but for everyday partings it's *arrivederci*.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "arrivederci" — *ar-ree-veh-DER-chee*
- arrivederci / au revoir / auf Wiedersehen — all "until we see again"
- "vedere" then English "video, vision" — the *see* root

Before you move on

What does *arrivederci* literally promise? ("Until we see each other again.") What French and German goodbyes share that exact idea? (*au revoir*, *auf Wiedersehen*.) Which heavier Italian goodbye means "to God," like Spanish *adiós*? (*addio*.) Next: "see you tomorrow" — **a domani**.

4.2 a domani — "see you tomorrow"

The "until re-seeing" pattern gives you a whole family of goodbyes: just name **when**. First: **a domani**, "to tomorrow."

Sounds you'll need

- **a domani** = *ah doh-**MAH**-nee*: clean open vowels, stress the *-ma-*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **a** = "to / until" (the same *a* from *arrivederci*).
- **domani** = "tomorrow," from Latin **dē māne**, *"from the morning."*

That word **māne** ("morning") is quietly shared across the Romance family, and you may have already met its Spanish child:

- Italian **domani** ("tomorrow") ← *dē māne*.
- Spanish **mañana** ← *(hōra) māneāna* — which means **both** "morning" *and* "tomorrow," because tomorrow *is* "the coming morning."

So *a domani* literally says **"until the morning [to come]."** You part by pointing at daybreak.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "a domani" — *ah doh-MAH-nee*
- Italian *domani* and Spanish *mañana* — both from *māne*, "morning"

Before you move on

What does *domani* come from, and what does it literally mean? (*Dē māne* — "from the morning.") Which Spanish word shares that *māne* root? (*Mañana* — morning *and* tomorrow.) Next: "see you soon" — **a presto**.

4.3 a presto — "see you soon"

Same frame, new "when": **a presto**, "to soon." And *presto* is a word English already borrowed whole — from stage magic and music.

Sounds you'll need

- **a presto** = *ah* ***PREH****-stoh*: clean *st*, crisp open *e*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **a** = "to / until."
- **presto** = "soon, quickly," from Latin **praestō**, *"at hand, ready, present"* (*prae-* "before" + *stō/stāre* "stand" — literally "standing before you," ready to hand).

English took **presto** straight from Italian:

- in **music**, *presto* means "fast."
- in stage magic, *"presto!"* means "quick — and there it is!"
- it shares that *stō* ("stand") root with *stare* from your how-are-you chapter, and with English **station**, **stable**, **status**.

So *a presto* is **"until [it is] soon / at hand"** — see you before long.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "a presto" — *ah PREH-stoh*
- "presto" as music ("fast") and magic ("presto!") — same word

Before you move on

What does *presto* mean, and where has English borrowed it? ("Soon / quickly" — in music and magic.) What "stand" root does it share with *stare*? (Latin *stō/stāre*.) Next: "see you later" — **a più tardi**.

4.4 a più tardi — "see you later"

The last "when" in the set: **a più tardi**, "to later" — literally "to *more late*." Two small words, both alive in English.

Sounds you'll need

- `piu-glide` — **più** = *pyoo*, one gliding syllable (the accent marks the stress).
- **a più tardi** = *ah pyoo* ***TAR****-dee*, tapped *r*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **a** = "to / until."
- **più** = "more," from Latin **plūs** — the very word English took for **plus**, and the root of **plural**, **surplus**.
- **tardi** = "late," from Latin **tardus**, *"slow, late"* → English **tardy**, **re-tard** ("to slow down"), **tardy** slip.

Together, *più tardi* = **"more late"** = "later." So *a più tardi* is "until [it's] more-late" — see you later on. (Italian builds "later" as *more late*, just as English does with the comparative *-er*.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "a più tardi" — *ah pyoo TAR-dee*
- "più" ~ English *plus*; "tardi" ~ English *tardy* — both borrowed
- the four goodbyes — arrivederci / a domani / a presto / a più tardi

Before you move on

What do *più* and *tardi* mean, and their English cousins? (*Più* = "more" ~ plus; *tardi* = "late" ~ tardy.) So *a più tardi* literally says? ("To more-late" → see you later.) Next: put the farewells together.

4.5 Practice — saying goodbye in Italian

No new words. You can now open a conversation, ask how someone is, and **close** it. Run the goodbyes until the right one comes automatically.

You'll want to know: the closings

Neutral / polite (anyone):

— È stato un piacere. **Arrivederci!** — **Arrivederci!**

With a "when" — pick the promise that fits:

— **A domani!** (see you tomorrow) — **A presto!** (see you soon)
— **A più tardi!** (see you later — same day)

Casual (a friend): the *ciao* you learned in Chapter 1 doubles as "bye" —

— **Ciao, a presto!**

What you've built this chapter

- **arrivederci** — goodbye ("until we re-see each other"; the *au revoir* / *auf Wiedersehen* family). Heavier, final variant: **addio** ("to God," twin of *adiós*).
- **a domani** — see you tomorrow (*domani* ← *dē māne*, "morning"; kin of Spanish *mañana*).
- **a presto** — see you soon (*presto* ← *praestō*, "at hand" — the English music/magic word).
- **a più tardi** — see you later (*più* ~ plus, *tardi* ~ tardy).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- greet, ask, and close — "Ciao! Come stai? … A domani!"
- choose the right goodbye — leaving till tomorrow / in an hour / for good

- arrivederci / au revoir / auf Wiedersehen — the “re-seeing” trio

Twice through: Open and close a whole tiny exchange without stopping.

Before you move on

Which goodbye means “until we see each other again”? (*Arrivederci.*) Which says “to the morning”? (*A domani.*) Which Italian goodbye matches Spanish *adiós* — “to God”? (*Addio.*) You can now run an Italian conversation start to finish.

Chapter 5

The First Verbs

Modes: **voice** (4) **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** first 2 of 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can build my own Italian sentences with -are verbs and drop the subject pronoun the way Italians do.
>
> *Conjugate parlare, abitare and lavorare across io, tu and lui with no pronoun spoken, then answer for yourself what you speak, where you live and where you work.*

5.1 parlare — "to speak," the model -are verb

Until now you've assembled fixed phrases. **parlare** ("to speak") is your first real **verb** and the model for Italian's largest **-are** family. Learn this pattern and you drive thousands.

Sounds you'll need

- `r-tap` — a single tapped *r*: **parlare** = *par-LA-reh*.
- `vowel-a-open` — clean open *ah* vowels.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

parlare comes from Late Latin **parabolāre**, *"to tell parables, to discourse"* — from **parabola**, "a comparison, a speech" (Greek *parabolē*). So to *speak* is, at root, to *tell parables*. The English family:

- **parable**, **parole** (a word of honour), **palaver**, **parley**, **parliament** (a *talking*-place).

And a lovely cross-link: **Italian *parlare* and French *parler* are the same word** — both from *parabolāre*. **Spanish went a different way**: its "to speak," *hablar*, is from *fabulārī* ("to chat," ← *fābula* → fable). So Italy and France "tell parables"; Spain "tells fables."

Grammar Lens: the -are present tense (and pro-drop)

Drop **-are** to get *parl-*, then add the endings:

person	**ending**	***parlare* →**
(io)	**-o**	**parlo** (I speak)
(tu)	**-i**	**parli** (you speak)
(lui/lei)	**-a**	**parla** (he/she speaks)
(noi)	-iamo	parliamo
(voi)	-ate	parlate
(loro)	-ano	parlano

Like Spanish (*hablo/hablas*), **Italian drops the subject pronoun** — *parlo* already says "I," so you don't need *io*. This closes a neat circle you've been building:

- **Drop the pronoun**: Spanish (*hablo*), **Italian (*parlo*)** — endings are distinct.
- **Keep the pronoun**: French (*je parle* — endings silent), German (*ich wohne* — grammar needs a subject).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "parlare" — *par-LA-reh*
- "parlo, parli, parla" — no *io* needed
- parlare / parler (same *parabolāre*) vs Spanish *hablar* (*fabulārī*)

Before you move on

What Latin word gives *parlare*, and which French verb is its twin? (*parabolāre* — French *parler*.) Which Romance "speak" verb is from a *different* root, and which? (Spanish *hablar* ← *fabulārī*.) Does Italian

keep or drop *io*, and why? (Drops it — the endings are distinct.) Next: **abitare**, "to live."

5.2 abitare — "to live," about *having a place*

A second **-are** verb — snap it into the endings you just learned. **abitare** ("to live, to dwell") lets you say *where* you live — and it's the twin of French *habiter*.

Sounds you'll need

- **abitare** = *a-bee-TA-reh* (Italian dropped the Latin *h*-, but the spelling and sense stayed). Clean open vowels, tapped *r*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

abitare comes from Latin **habitāre**, *"to dwell, to keep having [a place]"* — the **frequentative** of **habēre**, "to have." To *dwell* is to *keep having* your place. The English family:

- **habitat** — where a creature dwells; **inhabit**, **inhabitant**, **habitation**.
- via *habēre* ("have"): **habit** (what you keep having), **able**, **ability**.

French kept the *h* in spelling (*habiter*); Italian dropped it (*abitare*) — same Latin verb, same meaning. Now you can answer a *dove* ("where") question:

Abito a Roma. — "I live in Rome." (No *io* — pro-drop.)

Grammar Lens: same -are template

| (io) abito · (tu) abiti · (lui/lei) abita | (-o / -i / -a) |
| abitiamo · abitate · abitano | |
Identical to *parlare* — nothing new. That's the whole point of a regular pattern.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "abitare" — *a-bee-TA-reh*
- "abito, abiti, abita" — same endings as *parlo/parli/parla*
- "Abito a Roma"; and "abitare" ↔ English *habitat*

Before you move on

What Latin verb is *abitare* from, and what does it literally involve? (*habitāre* — "keep having a place," ← *habēre*, "to have.") English cousins? (Habitat, inhabit.) Say "I live in Rome." (*Abito a Roma.*) Next: **lavorare**, "to work."

5.3 lavorare — "to work," the honest kind

A third **-are** verb — and a satisfying twist. Where Spanish and French built their word for "work" out of **torture**, **Italian took a different road entirely**: *lavorare*, from plain Latin *"to labour."*

Sounds you'll need

- **lavorare** = *la-vo-RA-reh*: clean vowels, tapped *r*. (The *v* is a real *v*, unlike Spanish.)

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

lavorare comes from Latin **labōrāre**, *"to labour, to work, to strive"* — from **labor**, "toil, effort." No torture device here; just honest labour. The English family is large and dignified:

- **labor / labour**, **laborious**, **laboratory** (a *working*-place).
- **elaborate** ("worked *out*"), **collaborate** ("labour *together*").

Here's the cross-language payoff — the same idea, **two very different roots**:

language	"to work"	from	literal picture
Italian	*lavorare*	*labōrāre*	**labour, effort**
Spanish	*trabajar*	*tripalium*	**a torture rack**
French	*travailler*	*tripalium*	**a torture rack**

Spain and France remember work as *torture* (→ *travail/travel*); Italy remembers it as *labour*. A single glance at three verbs, and you see two Roman attitudes to a day's work.

Grammar Lens: same -are template

| (io) lavoro · (tu) lavori · (lui/lei) lavora | (-o / -i / -a) |

Lavoro a Milano. — "I work in Milan."

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "lavorare" — *la-vo-RA-reh*
- "lavoro, lavori, lavora"
- Italian *lavorare* (labour) vs Spanish *trabajar* / French *travailler* (torture)

Before you move on

What Latin word is *lavorare* from, and its English cousins? (*labōrāre* — labor, laboratory, elaborate.) How does its root differ from Spanish *trabajar* and French *travailler*? (Those are from *tripalium*, "torture"; Italian is from *labor*, "toil.") Say "I work in Milan." (*Lavoro a Milano.*) Next: your first sentence — **Parlo italiano**.

5.4 Parlo italiano — your first real sentence

The moment it pays off: you take a **verb** you conjugated and a **noun**, and build a sentence no one handed you — *Parlo italiano*, "I speak Italian." (Italian *parlo* covers both "I speak" and "I am speaking.")

You'll want to know: italiano

italiano = "Italian," from **Italia** — the ancient name of the peninsula itself. Its own origin is delightfully humble: many scholars trace *Italia* to Oscan **víteliú**, *"land of calves / young cattle"* (kin to Latin *vitulus*, "calf," and perhaps English *veal*). So *Italia* may literally have meant **"Calf-land."** Say it *ee-ta-LYA-no*.

You'll want to know: the assembled sentence

Snap two things you own together:

> **Parlo** (I speak, from *parlare*) + **italiano** (Italian) = **Parlo italiano.**

A complete, grammatical Italian sentence. Notice what's *not* there:

- **No *io*.** Italian drops it (like Spanish *hablo español*) — the *-o* of *parlo* already says "I". *Io parlo italiano* is fine for emphasis only.
- **No article** on the language: *parlo italiano*.

This closes the **pronoun-rule circle** you've watched across five languages:

	pronoun	**why**
Spanish / Italian	**dropped**	*hablo/parlo*: distinct endings
French *je parle*	kept	endings are silent
German *ich lerne*	kept	grammar needs an overt subject

Swap the pieces: **Abito a Roma.** · **Lavoro a Milano.** · **Parli italiano?**

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "Parlo italiano" — *PAR-lo ee-ta-LYA-no*
- drop the *io* — Italian doesn't need it (like Spanish, unlike French)
- "italiano" ← *Italia*, maybe "calf-land" — a humble, farmerly name

Before you move on

Where does *italiano* come from, and what might *Italia* have meant? (*Italia*; perhaps "land of calves.") In *Parlo italiano*, why no *io* and no article? (The *-o* ending is "I"; languages take no article.) Which two of the five languages *drop* the pronoun? (Spanish and Italian.) Next: practice.

5.5 Practice — making sentences with -are verbs

For the first time you're **building** Italian sentences from a pattern, not reciting phrases. Drill the three verbs until the endings are automatic — and remember, Italian drops the *io*.

Grammar Lens: conjugate on command

Run each through *io / tu / lui-lei* (pronoun dropped in speech):

- **parlare**: parlo · parli · parla
- **abitare**: abito · abiti · abita
- **lavorare**: lavoro · lavori · lavora

Same endings every time (**-o / -i / -a**), and no pronoun needed.

Grammar Lens: say something real

— **Parli** italiano? — Sì, **parlo** un po'. E tu? — Anch'io. **Dove abiti**? — **Abito** a Roma, e **lavoro** a Milano. — Grazie! — Prego.

What you've built this chapter

- **the regular -are present tense** — drop *-are*, add *-o/-i/-a/-iamo/-ate/-ano*; the pronoun is **dropped** (like Spanish).
- **parlare** (← *parabolāre* → parable; = French *parler*, vs Spanish *hablar*), **abitare** (← *habitāre* → habitat; twin of *habiter*), **lavorare** (← *labōrāre* → labor/laboratory — the "labour" road, not Spanish/French "torture").

- **Parlo italiano** — first self-assembled sentence (*italiano* ← *Italia*, perhaps "calf-land").
- **The pronoun circle across 5 languages**: ES *hablo* + IT *parlo* **drop**; FR *je parle* (silent endings) + DE *ich lerne* (grammar) **keep**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- conjugate all three verbs, io/tu/lui — no pronoun spoken
- answer about yourself — what you speak, where you live, where you work
- chain it — "Ciao! Parlo italiano. Parli italiano? … Arrivederci!"

Twice through: "Parli italiano? — Sì, parlo un po'."

Before you move on

What are the three singular *-are* endings? (*-o / -i / -a.*) Give the "I" forms of the three verbs. (*Parlo, abito, lavoro.*) Which languages drop the subject pronoun, and which keep it, and why? (Drop: ES/IT — distinct endings; keep: FR — silent endings, DE — grammar.) Italian now moves in real sentences.

Chapter 6

Numbers One to Ten

Modes: 👁 **eyes** (2) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** none of the 2 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can count from one to ten in Italian and hear the old numbers still sitting inside settembre and dicembre.
>
> *Count uno to dieci, pair sette, otto, nove and dieci with settembre, ottobre, novembre and dicembre, and hear Latin's -ct- flattened into the doubled -tt- of otto.*

6.1 uno, due, tre, quattro, cinque — counting to five

Of all the Romance sisters, **Italian kept the numbers closest to Latin** — it stayed in Italy, next to Rome, and wore the words down the least. Beside each you'll see the Spanish and French cousins for contrast.

Sounds you'll need

- `double-tt` — **quattro**: hold the double *t* audibly, *KWAT-tro* (Italian really doubles its consonants).
- `c-before-i` — **cinque** = *CHEEN-kweh*: *c* before *i/e* is a "ch" sound, but the *-que* stays a hard *kw*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Italian	← Latin	Spanish / French	English cousins
uno (1)	*ūnus*	*uno* / *un*	**unit, union, unique** (and *a/an*, *one*)
due (2)	*duo*	*dos* / *deux*	**duo, dual, duet, double**
tre (3)	*trēs*	*tres* / *trois*	**trio, triple, triangle**
quattro (4)	*quattuor*	*cuatro* / *quatre*	**quart, quarter, quatrain**
cinque (5)	*quīnque*	*cinco* / *cinq*	**quintet, quintessence**

Notice **cinque** — Italian kept Latin *quīnque* almost whole (-*que* and all), while Spanish softened it to *cinco* and French clipped it to *cinq*. And **quattro** is why a musical foursome is a *quartet* and four singers make a *quattro*-anything. Italian is the sister who changed her Latin the least.

Grammar Lens: uno → un / uno / una

uno is also "a/an," and it flexes by gender and the following sound: **un** (before most masc. nouns), **uno** (before tricky masc. clusters like *s+consonant* or *z*-), **una** (fem.). *un caffè* "a/one coffee," *una birra* "a/one beer." The others (*due, tre…*) don't change.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "uno, due, tre, quattro, cinque" — count up
- each with its English cousin — "due/duo, tre/trio, quattro/quart, cinque/quintet"
- "un caffè, una birra" — *uno* → un/una before a noun

Before you move on

Give 1–5 in Italian. (*Uno, due, tre, quattro, cinque.*) Which Italian number kept Latin *quīnque* most intact, versus Spanish and French? (*cinque*, vs *cinco* / *cinq.*) What does *un/una* mean besides "one"? ("A/an.") Next: **6–10**, and the months hidden inside them.

6.2 sei, sette, otto, nove, dieci — and the calendar's secret

The rest of the count hides a calendar fact: **settembre–dicembre are Latin for 7, 8, 9, 10.** Italian even keeps the old Latin double consonants that show it.

Sounds you'll need

- `double-tt` — **sette** = *SET-teh*, **otto** = *OT-toh*: lean on the doubled *t*, a giveaway that Latin's *-pt-* and *-ct-* both collapsed into *-tt-*.
- `c-before-i` — **dieci** = *DYE-chee* (the *c* before *i* → "ch").

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Italian	← Latin	Spanish twin	English cousins
sei (6)	*sex*	*seis*	**sextet, sextant**
sette (7)	*septem*	*siete*	**settembre** (the *7th* month!), septet
otto (8)	*octō*	*ocho*	**ottobre** (8th), **octave, octopus**
nove (9)	*novem*	*nueve*	**novembre** (9th), novena
dieci (10)	*decem*	*diez*	**dicembre** (10th), **decimal, decade**

Watch the doubled consonants do historical work: Latin *septem* had a *-pt-* that Italian smoothed to *-tt-* → **sette**; Latin *octō* had a *-ct-* that likewise became *-tt-* → **otto**. Italian didn't drop those clusters (as French did in *huit*) — it **assimilated** them into twins. So *otto* and *ottobre* still show the 8 side by side.

Grammar Lens: why the months are "off by two"

Settembre means "7th," but it's the **9th** month. The old **Roman year began in March**, so *September* really was the seventh; later *luglio* and *agosto* (July and August, for Julius and Augustus) pushed the counting months down two slots. The Latin numbers stuck to the labels. Every *dicembre*, you say Roman "**ten**" — just as in Spanish *diciembre* and French *décembre*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "sei, sette, otto, nove, dieci" — finish the count
- "sette/settembre, otto/ottobre, nove/novembre, dieci/dicembre"

- "octō → otto" — the *-ct-* becoming a doubled *-tt-*

Before you move on

Give 6–10 in Italian. (*Sei, sette, otto, nove, dieci.*) What happened to Latin's *-ct-* in *octō → otto*? (It assimilated to a doubled *-tt-*.) Why is *dicembre* Latin for "ten"? (The Roman year began in March.) Next chapter builds on this toward time and days.

Chapter 7

Days of the Week

Modes: 👁 **eyes** (2) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** none of the 2 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name all seven Italian days and say why sabato and domenica broke away from the planets.
>
> *Run lunedì to venerdì with the planet inside each, then sabato from the Sabbath and domenica as the Lord's day, matched against Spanish sábado and domingo.*

7.1 lunedì to venerdì — the planet-week, Italian-style

Italy sat at the centre of the Roman world, so its weekday names are the **planet-week** almost undisturbed — the same map of the sky French uses. The tell is the little accented **-dì** at the end of each.

Sounds you'll need

- `final-stress-i` — the **-dì** carries a **written accent** and the **stress**: *lu-ne-DÌ*, *mar-te-DÌ*. That accent marks "day" (*diēs*) and where your voice lands.
- `c-before-i` — **mercoledì** = *mer-co-le-DÌ* (hard *c* here, before *o*).

Grammar Lens: [planet] + dì

dì is Latin **diēs**, "day" — the same *-di* you'd hear in French *lundi*. Before it sits a **planet-god**:

Italian	← **Latin**	**planet**	**Spanish twin**	**French twin**
lunedì	*lūnae diēs*	Moon	*lunes*	*lundi*
martedì	*Martis diēs*	Mars	*martes*	*mardi*
mercoledì	*Mercuriī diēs*	Mercury	*miércoles*	*mercredi*
giovedì	*Jovis diēs*	Jupiter (*Giove*)	*jueves*	*jeudi*
venerdì	*Veneris diēs*	Venus (*Venere*)	*viernes*	*vendredi*

Line up the three sisters — *lunedì / lunes / lundi* — and you're looking at one Roman word, *lūnae diēs*, worn three ways. Italian and French keep the day-word at the **end** (*lune-dì*, *lun-di*); Spanish clipped it off entirely (*lunes*). And *giovedì* wears **Giove**, the Italian name of Jupiter — the same king-god English honours as Thor in *Thursday*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "lunedì, martedì, mercoledì, giovedì, venerdì" — mind the final stress
- the three-sister line — "lunedì / lunes / lundi", "martedì / martes / mardi"
- "-dì = diēs = day" — the accented tail

Before you move on

What is the accented *-dì*, and from what Latin word? ("Day," ← *diēs*.) Which planet is *giovedì*? (Jupiter — *Giove*.) How do Italian/French treat the day-word versus Spanish? (IT/FR keep it at the end, *-dì/-di*; Spanish dropped it, *lunes*.) Next: the **weekend** — *sabato* and *domenica*.

7.2 sabato and domenica — the religious weekend

The five weekdays were planets; the two weekend days are **faith**. Here the accented *-dì* disappears, because these names never came from *diēs* + a god — they came from the Sabbath and the Lord.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Italian	← Latin	meaning	Spanish twin
sabato	*Sabbatum* ← Hebrew *shabbāt*	the "**Sabbath**," the day of rest	*sábado*
domenica	*(diēs) Dominica* ← *Dominus*	"the **Lord's** day"	*domingo*

- **sabato** is the **Sabbath** — Latin *Sabbatum* straight from Hebrew *shabbāt*, "to cease, to rest." Where English kept the planet (**Satur**day = Saturn), Italian, Spanish, and French all took the Jewish rest-day instead (*sabato / sábado / samedi*).
- **domenica** is "the **Lord's** day," *diēs Dominica*, from *Dominus* "lord, master" (→ English *dominion, dominate, dame, don*). Christianity renamed the old "Sun's day": English still says **Sun**day, but Italian and Spanish point to the Lord (*domenica / domingo*). Note *domenica* is **feminine** (*la domenica*) — *diēs* went feminine here.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the full week — "lunedì … venerdì, sabato, domenica"
- "sabato = Sabbath, domenica = the Lord's day" — faith, not planets
- the sisters — "sabato / sábado", "domenica / domingo"

Before you move on

Give all seven Italian days. (*Lunedì … domenica.*) Where does *sabato* come from? (The **Sabbath**, *Sabbatum* ← Hebrew *shabbāt.*) What does *domenica* mean, and its Spanish twin? ("The **Lord's** day"; *domingo.*) Next chapter builds on this toward telling the time.

Chapter 8

Telling Time

Modes: **voice** (1) **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** first 1 of 2 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can tell the time in Italian and use mezzogiorno and mezzanotte for the two hours that need no number.
>
> *Say è mezzogiorno and è mezzanotte, break each into mezzo or mezza plus giorno or notte, and explain why the half changes gender between them.*

8.1 ora — the hour, told with "le"

Italian's word for "hour" is **ora**, straight from Latin **hōra** (which Rome took from Greek *hŏrā*, "a time of day"). Telling the time in Italian has one neat twist: you use the **feminine article** and let *ore* ("hours") stay implied.

Sounds you'll need

- `open-o` — **ora** = *OH-ra*, open *o*, single tapped *r*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ora ← Latin **hōra** ← Greek **hŏrā**. It's the closest of the sisters to the Latin: French wore it to *heure*, but Italian barely touched it — *hōra* → *ora* (Italian dropped the silent Latin *h-* in spelling, too). Same word as English *hour*, and as German's borrowed *Uhr*.

Grammar Lens: "è l'una" but "sono le due"

Here's the twist. Italian tells the time with the **feminine article** (because *ora/ore* is feminine), and the verb agrees with the number:

> **È l'una.** — "It is one o'clock." (singular: *è* "it is" + *l'una* = "the one [hour]") **Sono le due.** — "It is two o'clock." (plural: *sono* "they are" + *le due* = "the two [hours]") **Sono le dieci.** — "It is ten o'clock."

Literally "**they are** the two [hours]" — Italian counts the hours as feminine things and drops the word *ore* entirely; the article **le** carries it. Only **one o'clock** is singular (*è l'una*); from two on, it's *sono le …*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "ora" — *OH-ra*
- "è l'una … sono le due, sono le tre, sono le quattro"
- "ora / heure / Uhr / hour" — all Latin *hōra*

Before you move on

What word is *ora* from, and its sisters? (Latin *hōra* ← Greek *hṓrā*; French *heure*, German *Uhr*, English *hour*.) Why "*sono le* due" but "*è l'*una"? (Plural hours take *sono le …*; one o'clock is singular *è l'una*.) What word does the *le* stand in for? (*ore*, "hours" — feminine.) Next: **mezzogiorno** and **mezzanotte** — noon and midnight.

8.2 mezzogiorno and mezzanotte — Italy's noon and midnight

The two unnumbered hours. **mezzogiorno** (noon) and **mezzanotte** (midnight) are, like their French cousins, the **middle** of the day and the night — built from *mezzo* "half/middle" plus *giorno* "day" and *notte* "night."

Sounds you'll need

- `double-zz` — **mezzo** = *MED-dzo*, the doubled *zz* a hard "ts/dz" — lean on it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The front piece is **mezzo/mezza**, "half, middle," from Latin **medius** (cousin of English *medium, mid*, and of French *mi-* in *midi*):

Italian	**=**	**← Latin**	**literally**
mezzogiorno	*mezzo* + *giorno*	*medius* + *diurnum*	"**mid-day**" (noon)
mezzanotte	*mezza* + *notte*	*media* + *noctem*	"**mid-night**" (midnight)

- **mezzogiorno** = "mid-day." *giorno* ("day") is from Latin *diurnum* ("of the day") — the same root as English *journal* and *journey* (a day's travel). So noon is "the middle of the day-span."
- **mezzanotte** = "mid-night." *notte* ("night") ← *noctem*, twin of English *night* and French *nuit*. *mezza* is the **feminine** "half" (agreeing with the feminine *notte*), where *mezzo* is masculine (with *giorno*) — the article system you just met, again.

To use them, they *are* the hour:

> **È mezzogiorno.** — "It is noon." **È mezzanotte.** — "It is midnight."

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "mezzogiorno" (noon), "mezzanotte" (midnight)
- break them — "mezzo (middle) + giorno (day)", "mezza + notte (night)"
- "È mezzogiorno. È mezzanotte." — singular *è*, no number

Before you move on

What do *mezzogiorno* and *mezzanotte* literally mean? ("Mid-day" and "mid-night.") What is *mezzo/mezza* from, and its French cousin? (Latin *medius*; French *mi-* in *midi/minuit*.) Why *mezza*notte but *mezzo*giorno? (*mezza* is feminine for *notte*, *mezzo* masculine for *giorno*.) Next chapter builds on this toward months and family.

Chapter 9

Months and Seasons

Modes: **voice** (1) **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** none of the 2 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name the Italian months and seasons and say what primavera literally promises.
>
> *Give la primavera, l'estate, l'autunno, l'inverno, read primavera as prima vera, the first green, and trace stagione back to statiō, a standing of the year.*

9.1 i mesi — Rome's own months

Sitting next to Rome, Italian kept the month names **closest to Latin** of all the sisters — the same procession of gods and Caesars, barely worn. And two things you know pay off: *marzo* is the war-god of *martedì*, and *settembre– dicembre* are the Latin numbers 7–10.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Italian	← Latin	who / what	Spanish twin
gennaio	*Januarius*	**Janus**, god of beginnings	*enero*
febbraio	*Februarius*	the *Februa* purification	*febrero*
marzo	*Martius*	**Mars** — the god of **martedì**!	*marzo*
aprile	*Aprilis*	*aperire* "to open"	*abril*
maggio	*Maius*	**Maia**, growth-goddess	*mayo*
giugno	*Junius*	**Juno**, queen of gods	*junio*
luglio	*Julius*	**Julius Caesar**	*julio*
agosto	*Augustus*	emperor **Augustus**	*agosto*
settembre	*september*	"**7th**" (*septem*)	*septiembre*
ottobre	*october*	"**8th**" (*octo*)	*octubre*
novembre	*november*	"**9th**" (*novem*)	*noviembre*
dicembre	*december*	"**10th**" (*decem*)	*diciembre*

The Italian tells: *gennaio* kept the *-aio* of *Januarius*, and *settembre/ottobre* keep the doubled/assimilated look (*ottobre*, like *otto*). And two payoffs land:

- **marzo = Mars = martedì.** The month and Tuesday honour the *same* war-god — *Martius* and *Martedì*. One unlocks the other.
- **settembre…dicembre = 7…10.** Still the Latin numbers, because the Roman year began in **March**; then *luglio* (Julius) and *agosto* (Augustus) were inserted and shifted the count.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the twelve — "gennaio, febbraio, marzo … novembre, dicembre"

- "marzo / martedì — both Mars"
- "settembre = 7, dicembre = 10"

Before you move on

Which god links *marzo* and *martedì*? (**Mars**.) Why is *dicembre* Latin for "ten"? (The Roman year began in March.) Which two months honour real **people**? (*Luglio* — Julius; *agosto* — Augustus.) Next: the **stagioni**, the seasons.

9.2 le stagioni — the four seasons

The word for "season," **stagione**, is itself a small lesson: it's Latin **statiō**, a "standing" — a fixed *station* of the year (cousin of English *station, stage*). And the loveliest of the four, **primavera**, means the "**first green**."

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Italian	← Latin	literally
la primavera (spring)	*prīma vēra*	"**first spring / first green**" (*prima* "first" + *vera* ← *ver* "spring")
l'estate (summer)	*aestas / aestātem*	"the heat, the hot season"
l'autunno (autumn)	*autumnus*	"autumn" (twin of English *autumn*)
l'inverno (winter)	*hibernum*	"the wintry season" (cousin of *hibernate*)

- **primavera** = *prima* + *vera*: the "first spring." Latin *vēr* was the word for spring; Italian (and Spanish, and Portuguese) built "prima-vera," the year's *first* season — the same idea French once had in *primevère*.
- **estate** ← *aestas*, "heat." **autunno** ← *autumnus*, the same word English borrowed. **inverno** ← *hibernum* "wintry" — English **hibernate** is "to spend the *inverno*."

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "la primavera, l'estate, l'autunno, l'inverno"
- "primavera = prima + vera (first green)"; "inverno ~ hibernate"
- "stagione ← statiō — a 'standing' of the year, like station"

Before you move on

Name the four Italian seasons. (*Primavera, estate, autunno, inverno.*) What does *primavera* literally mean? ("**First spring / first green**.") What Latin word is *stagione* from, and its English cousin? (*Statiō* "a standing"; *station.*) Next chapter builds on this toward family and food.

Chapter 10

Family

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (2) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 2 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name my parents and my siblings in Italian and spot the little-ending Italian bolted onto frater and soror.
>
> *Say il padre, la madre, il fratello, la sorella, then rebuild fratello from frāter plus the diminutive -ello and reach English fraternal and sorority from the same roots.*

10.1 il padre, la madre — closest to Latin

Italian, as ever, stays nearest to Rome. Its **padre** ("father") and **madre** ("mother") barely moved from Latin **pater** and **māter** — Latin just softened the *-t-* to *-d-*. If you know the Latin, you nearly know the Italian.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **il padre** ("father") ← Latin **pater** (*-t-* → *-d-*).
- **la madre** ("mother") ← Latin **māter** (*-t-* → *-d-*).

Articles: *il* padre (masculine), *la* madre (feminine).
English already borrowed one of these whole: a **padre** is what English (and Spanish-influenced) speakers call a priest or military chaplain — *padre* itself, untouched.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Italian "parents" is **i genitori** — not from *parens* but from Latin **genitor**, "the **begetter**," from *gignere* "to beget/bring forth." That root *gen-* "give birth to" is everywhere in English: **genital, progenitor, genesis, generate, genus, gene**. So *i genitori* are literally "the begetters." (Beware the **false friend**: Italian *parenti* means **relatives** in general, *not* "parents"!)
The Latin-through-English adjectives still come from *pater/māter*: **paternal** and **maternal** — the same roots as French *père/mère* and, by Grimm's law, English *father/mother*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "il padre, la madre" — soft *-d-* where Latin had *-t-*
- "i genitori = the parents; *genitor* = begetter → genesis, gene"
- the false-friend warning — "*parenti* = relatives, NOT parents"

Before you move on

Give "father" and "mother" with articles. (**il padre, la madre**.) What single sound did Latin *pater/māter* soften to? (The *-t-* became **-d-**.) What does **genitori** literally mean, and name an English cousin. ("The **begetters**"; genesis/gene/progenitor.) What does the false friend *parenti* mean? (**Relatives**, not parents.) Next: **fratello** and **sorella**.

10.2 il fratello, la sorella — brother and sister, with a little-ending

Here Italian does something charming. Where French kept *frère* and *sœur* bare, Italian rebuilt "brother" and "sister" with its beloved **diminutive** endings — literally "**little brother**" and "**little sister**" — and those forms became the everyday words.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **il fratello** ("brother") ← Latin **frāter** + the diminutive **-ellus** → *fraterellus* → *fratello*, once "little brother."
- **la sorella** ("sister") ← Latin **soror** + the diminutive **-ella** → *sorella*, once "little sister."

The root still shows: **frat-** and **soror-**, the same roots English turns into **frat**ernal, **frat**ernity, **friar** and **soror**ity, **soror**al. Italian just wrapped them in the affectionate *-ello/-ella* that also gives *fratello*'s cousins across the language (*-ello* on *poverello* "poor little one," *-ella* on countless names).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all four — "il padre, la madre, il fratello, la sorella"
- the build — "*frater* + *-ello* → fratello, 'little brother'"
- "fratello → fraternal; sorella → sorority"

Before you move on

Give "brother" and "sister" with articles. (**il fratello, la sorella**.) What did Italian **add** to Latin *frāter/soror* to make them? (A **diminutive** ending, *-ello / -ella* — "little brother/sister.") Name an English cousin of each root. (*frat-* → fraternal/friar; *soror-* → sorority.) Next chapter: sentences about the family.

Chapter 11

Bread, Water, and Wine

Modes: **voice** (2) **Hands-free start:** all 2 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name bread, water and wine in Italian and show how acqua kept the whole of Latin's aqua.
>
> *Say il pane, l'acqua and il vino, hold the doubled -cq- of acqua against French's worn-down eau, and follow pane out to the companion who shares it.*

11.1 il pane — bread, and its companions

il pane ("bread") — and, true to form, Italian keeps it **closest to Latin**: *pānis* → *pane*, barely touched. Its root carries the same warm story as the French *pain*: a **companion** is one you **share bread** with.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **il pane** ("bread") ← Latin **pānis** — masculine, *il* pane; the plural is *i pani*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **companion / company** ← *com-* ("with") + *pānis* — "one you **break bread with**."
- **pantry**, **pannier** (a bread-basket).
- And a purely Italian gem: **companatico** — the word for

"**whatever you eat with bread**" (cheese, salami, anything on it). The bread is the given; the *companatico* is what joins it — the same *com-* + *pānis* idea, alive in one Italian word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "il pane" — open *e*; plural "i pani"
- "pane → companion, companatico" — bread and what joins it

Before you move on

Give "bread" with its article. (**il pane**.) What Latin word, and how much did Italian change it? (*pānis* — barely: *pānis* → *pane*.) What does *companatico* mean, and how does it use the bread-root? ("What you eat **with** bread" — *com-* "with" + *pānis*.) Next: **l'acqua** and **il vino**.

11.2 l'acqua, il vino — water and wine, close to the source

The Italian table's two drinks — and a neat contrast with French. Where French dissolved Latin *aqua* into a bare **eau** ("oh"), Italian kept it almost **whole**: **acqua**, with the *aqua* still ringing in it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **l'acqua** ("water") ← Latin **aqua**. Italian barely moved it — it even **doubles** the sound with **-cq-** (*AH-kwa*), holding onto the hard *qu* that French threw away. Set them side by side: Latin *aqua* → Italian **acqua** (kept) vs French **eau** (worn to a vowel). English borrowed the same loud original for **aquatic, aquarium, aqueduct**. Takes *l'* before the vowel.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **il vino** ("wine") ← Latin **vīnum** — clean and close, like everything Italian. The same word travelled into English as **wine**, and gives **vine, vinegar, vintage, vineyard, vinyl**. Masculine: *il* vino.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "l'acqua, il vino" — *acqua* with the doubled *-cq-*
- the contrast — "Latin *aqua* → Italian **acqua** (kept), French **eau** (worn away)"
- "acqua ↔ aquarium; vino → wine, vinegar"

Before you move on

Give "water" and "wine" with articles. (**l'acqua, il vino**.) How does Italian *acqua* differ from French *eau*, from the same *aqua*? (Italian **kept** it — even doubling *-cq-*; French wore it to a single vowel.) Name an English cousin of each. (*acqua* → aquatic/aquarium; *vino* → wine/vinegar.) Next chapter: asking for these at a table.

Chapter 12

Numbers Eleven to Twenty

Modes: 👁 **eyes** (2) 🎧 **Hands-free start:** none of the 2 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can count from eleven to twenty in Italian and hear the ten jump to the front at diciassette.
>
> *Run undici to venti, listen for the turn from se-dici to dici-assette where the ten moves to the front, and place Italian's break at 17 beside Portuguese's at 16.*

12.1 undici → sedici — the ten you can still see

True to form, Italian keeps the teens **closest to Latin** — so close that the word for "ten" is still sitting in plain sight inside each one. Where French wore *decem* down to a bare **-ze**, Italian kept **-dici**.

Grammar Lens: six fusions

	Italian	← **Latin**	**build**
11	**undici**	*ūndecim*	un + dici
12	**dodici**	*duodecim*	do + dici
13	**tredici**	*trēdecim*	tre + dici
14	**quattordici**	*quattuordecim*	quattor + dici
15	**quindici**	*quīndecim*	quin + dici
16	**sedici**	*sēdecim*	se + dici

Every one is **digit + -dici**, and **-dici** is Latin **decem**, "ten" — the same ten you say as **dieci** (10). Compare the sisters and Italian's clarity jumps

out:

- Latin *sēdecim* → Italian **sedici** (ten still audible) · French **seize** (ten worn to a *-ze*) · Portuguese **dezesseis** (rebuilt from scratch).

The digits are your Chapter 6 numbers barely changed: *tre*→*tre-*, *quattro*→ *quattor-*, *cinque*→*quin-*, *sei*→*se-*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "undici, dodici, tredici, quattordici, quindici, sedici"
- the ten inside — "-dici = *decem* = **dieci**"
- the three-sister line — "sedici / seize / dezesseis, one Latin word"

Before you move on

Count 11 to 16 in Italian. (*Undici, dodici, tredici, quattordici, quindici, sedici.*) What is the **-dici** in every one? (Latin **decem**, "ten" — the same as *dieci.*) Which order are they built in — digit first or ten first? (**Digit first**: *tre*-dici = "three-ten".) Next: at **17**, Italian flips *both* its strategy **and** its direction.

12.2 diciassette → venti — the count turns around

Watch the language change direction. Through **sedici** (16), Italian put the **digit first** and the ten last. At **17**, it turns the whole thing around and puts the **ten first** — and it keeps the *-dici* right there so you can see it happen.

Grammar Lens: the reversal

	Italian	build	order
16	**sedici**	*se* + *dici*	**six-ten**
17	**diciassette**	*dici* + *(a)* + *sette*	**ten-and-seven**
18	**diciotto**	*dici* + *otto*	ten-eight
19	**diciannove**	*dici* + *(an)* + *nove*	ten-nine
20	**venti**	← *vīgintī*	—

Same building blocks — *dici* ("ten") and your Chapter 6 digits — but from 17 the **ten leads**. The little linking sounds (*diciAssette*, *diciANnove*) are just Italian smoothing the joint, the doubling it loves.

What you've built: three different breaks

This "give up fusing, go transparent" seam happens in every Romance sister, but **not at the same place**:

language	fuses up to	goes transparent at
Portuguese	*quinze* (15)	**16** — *dezesseis*
French	*seize* (16)	**17** — *dix-sept*
Italian	*sedici* (16)	**17** — *diciassette*

Three languages, one inherited Latin system, three different breaking points. (And German, you may recall, never breaks at all.)
venti (20) ← *vīgintī*, the same root as French *vingt* and English **vigesimal**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- 16→20 — "sedici, diciassette, diciotto, diciannove, venti"
- the turn — "*se*-dici (six-ten) → *dici*-assette (ten-seven)"
- the whole run, undici to venti

Before you move on

What changes between *sedici* and *diciassette*? (The **order** — the **ten moves to the front**; digit-first becomes ten-first.) Where do the three Romance sisters break? (**Portuguese at 16**, **French and Italian at 17**.) What Latin word gives *venti*? (*vīgintī* — like French *vingt*, English *vigesimal*.) Next chapter: numbers in use.

Chapter 13

Colours

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (2) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 2 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name black, white, red and blue in Italian and say which of them Italian borrowed rather than inherited.
>
> *Say nero, bianco, rosso and blu, add azzurro for gli Azzurri, and sort the four: nero and rosso inherited, bianco and blu Germanic loans, azzurro out of Arabic lāzaward.*

13.1 nero, bianco — one Roman, one Lombard

Italy's two most basic colours came from **two different peoples**. One is Rome's own word. The other arrived with the Germanic tribes who settled the peninsula after Rome fell.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

nero ("black") ← Latin ***niger***. Straight inheritance, barely changed: *niger* → *nigrum* → *nero*. The same *niger* gives English *denigrate*, "to blacken."

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin's white was ***albus***. Italian doesn't use it. Instead: **bianco**, from Germanic ***blank*** — "**shining, gleaming**" — most likely carried in by the **Lombards**, the Germanic people who ruled northern Italy for two centuries and left their name on **Lombardia**.
The same word became French *blanc* and Portuguese *branco*. Germanic lending **into** Romance is the reverse of the usual direction, and here the

loan won so completely that Latin's own word was pushed out of the colour slot altogether.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

word	meaning	the white inside
alba	dawn	the sky turning white
albume	egg white	the white part
Albania, *Alpi*	(place names)	"the white ones"
album (Eng.)	album	a blank white tablet

Latin's white is still here — just doing other jobs.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "nero, bianco"
- "il vino bianco, il vino rosso" — Ch.11's wine, coloured
- "il pane bianco" — Ch.11's bread
- "l'**alba**" — and hear Latin's forgotten white

Before you move on

Which colour is Rome's own? (**Nero** ← *niger*.) Where does **bianco** come from? (**Germanic *blank***, "shining" — likely via the **Lombards**.) Why is that surprising? (Latin normally lends **to** Germanic, not the reverse.) Where did *albus* survive? (In **alba**, "dawn," and **albume** — no longer a colour.) Next: **rosso** and **blu**, and one more traveller.

13.2 rosso, blu — and the blue Italy plays in

One very old word, one more Germanic loan — and a third blue that came all the way from Persia by way of Arabic.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

rosso ← Latin ***russus*** ("red"), from PIE ***h₁rewd^h-***. That root is one of the oldest colour words we can reconstruct:

language	**word**
Italian	**rosso**
French	**rouge** (← *rubeus*)
English	**red**, *rust*, *ruby*
German	**rot**

Rosso and *red* are **cousins**, not borrowings — separated for millennia. Note the **double s**: hold it. *Roso* and *rosso* are different words.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

blu ← Germanic ***blāo***, exactly like French *bleu*. Chapter pattern confirmed: **bianco** and **blu**, Italian's white and blue, are both **Germanic imports**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Italian has a second blue, and it's the famous one: **azzurro**, from Arabic ***lāzaward*** ("lapis lazuli"), itself from Persian ***lāžward***. The initial *l-* was swallowed — heard as an article and dropped — leaving *azur/azzurro*. The same journey gave Spanish and Portuguese **azul**, French **azur**, and English **azure**.
Italy's national teams are **gli Azzurri**, "the blue ones" — named, at the end of a very long chain, after a **blue stone mined in Afghanistan**.

What you've built: the colour paths

Italian	**source**
nero	Latin *niger*
bianco	**Germanic** *blank*
rosso	Latin *russus* (ancient PIE root)
blu	**Germanic** *blāo*
azzurro	**Arabic** *lāzaward*

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “rosso, blu, azzurro”
- “il vino rosso” — Chapter 11’s wine
- the cousins — “rosso · red · rot · rouge”
- “gli Azzurri” — and think of the stone

Before you move on

Is *rosso* related to English *red* by borrowing or descent? (**Descent** — PIE ***$h_1$rewd^h-***.) Which two Italian colours are Germanic loans? (**Bianco** and **blu**.) Where does **azzurro** come from? (**Arabic *lāzaward***, “lapis lazuli” — via Persian; the *l-* was lost as if it were an article.) What are Italy’s teams called? (**Gli Azzurri**.) Next chapter: attaching these colours to the nouns you know.

Chapter 14

Having and Telling Your Age

Modes: **voice** (1) **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** none of the 2 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can ask an Italian's age and give my own, saying that I have my years rather than that I am them.
>
> *Ask Quanti anni hai?, answer Ho venti anni with the doubled nn held, and hear hanno and anno come out identical because avere's h is silent.*

14.1 avere — "to have"

Italian's workhorse verb — and the home of the language's **only silent letter**, which is there for a reason worth knowing.

You'll want to know: the forms

ho	**abbiamo**
hai	**avete**
ha	**hanno**

Look at which forms carry an **h**: *ho, hai, ha, hanno.* And which don't: *abbiamo, avete.*

Grammar Lens: why silent h survives

Italian threw the Latin **h** away almost completely — it is never pronounced, and *uomo* (← *homō*) and *erba* (← *herba*) simply dropped it. But in *avere* it stayed, because without it these words would collide:

with h	without h	meaning
ho — I have	**o**	"or"
hai — you have	**ai**	"to the"
ha — he/she has	**a**	"to"
hanno — they have	**anno**	"**year**"

Four minimal pairs, all extremely common. The **h** is silent, does nothing to the sound, and is kept **only so your eye can tell the words apart**. Spelling doing a job pronunciation can't — hold onto *hanno* vs *anno*; it comes back in the next lesson.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

avere ← Latin ***habēre***, the same source as French *avoir*. English took it as a whole family: **habit** (what you have regularly), **inhabit**, **exhibit** ("hold out"), **prohibit** ("hold back").
Note *abbiamo* — the **bb** is the old *habē-* resurfacing in the *noi* form, while *ho* wore down to a single vowel.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "ho, hai, ha, abbiamo, avete, hanno"
- "Ho un fratello" ("I have a brother") — Ch. 10's family
- the pair — "**hanno** they have · **anno** a year"
- "Abbiamo pane e vino" — Ch. 11's food

Before you move on

Give the six forms. (*Ho, hai, ha, abbiamo, avete, hanno.*) Which carry an **h**? (*Ho, hai, ha, hanno.*) Is it pronounced? (**No** — never.) Then why is it there? (To keep them apart from **o, ai, a, anno** in **writing**.) What root is *avere* from? (Latin ***habēre*** → *habit/inhabit/exhibit.*) Next: *anno* takes centre stage.

14.2 ho venti anni — having your years

Italian states age with **avere**, not *essere*. And the silent **h** from last lesson stops being trivia here — it becomes the difference between two real sentences.

You'll want to know: the phrase

Quanti anni hai? — "How many years do you **have**?" **Ho venti anni.** — "I **have** twenty years."

Essere is wrong here. *Sono venti anni* does not mean "I am twenty."

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

anno ("year") ← Latin ***annus*** → English **annual**, **anniversary**, **annals**, *per annum*. Chapter 9's months and seasons came from the same calendar vocabulary.
Note the **double n**: *a-nno*, held. Italian's double consonants are real length, not decoration.

Grammar Lens: h earns its keep

Now put the last lesson to work:

sentence	meaning
Hanno venti anni.	"**They have** twenty years."
anno	"**year**"

Hanno and *anno* sound **exactly the same**. Only the silent **h** tells them apart — and in a sentence about years, both words show up at once. That is precisely why Italian kept a letter it never pronounces.

Grammar Lens: who has and who is

language	
Italian	*h**o** venti anni* — **have**
French	*j'**ai** vingt ans* — **have**
Spanish	*t**engo** veinte años* — **have**
Portuguese	*t**enho** vinte anos* — **have**
German	*ich **bin** zwanzig Jahre alt* — **be**
English	*I **am** twenty* — **be**

Romance has its years; Germanic is its years.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "Quanti anni hai?"
- "Ho venti anni" — hold the **nn**
- your own age, using Ch. 12's numbers
- the pair aloud — "**hanno** … **anno**" — identical sound

Before you move on

Which verb does Italian use for age? (***Avere***, never *essere*.) What does *ho venti anni* literally say? ("I **have** twenty years.") Where does *anno* come from? (Latin ***annus*** → *annual/anniversary*.) What separates *hanno* from *anno*? (**Only the silent h** — they sound identical.) Which two languages say "I **am**" instead? (**German and English**.)

Chapter 15

Two Italian Pasts

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (2) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 2 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say what I did in Italian with the everyday passato prossimo, and recognise the passato remoto when it turns up.
>
> *Put ha parlato beside parlò, line parlò up with Spanish habló and Portuguese falou, and place the remoto as ordinary speech in Palermo but literary in Milan.*

15.1 ho parlato — the past built from "have"

Italy's everyday past tense, and you already own both halves: **avere** from last chapter, and Chapter 5's verbs.

Grammar Lens: the compound-past recipe

avere (conjugated) + **past participle**

infinitive	ends in	participle
parl**are**	-are	parl**ato**
lavor**are**	-are	lavor**ato**
cred**ere**	-ere	cred**uto**
dorm**ire**	-ire	dorm**ito**

ho parlato	I spoke / I have spoken
hai parlato	you spoke
ha parlato	he/she spoke
abbiamo parlato	we spoke
hanno parlato	they spoke

The silent **h** from last chapter is doing its job again: *ho parlato* on the page can't be misread as *o parlato* ("or spoken").
Note **parlato** keeps the *-t-* that French wore away: Italian *parlato*, French *parlé*, both from Latin ***-ātum***. Italian is the more conservative sister — the same pattern as Chapter 11's *acqua* against French *eau*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin could say:

> ***habeō litterās scriptās*** — "I **have** letters **written**."

Not a past tense: *avere* in its plain sense of **possessing**, with *scriptās* as an **adjective** agreeing with *litterās*. Over centuries "I possess a written thing" slid into simply "**I wrote**" — a possessive construction **hardened into a tense**.
The fossil survives. When the object comes **before** the verb, the participle still agrees with it, exactly as an adjective would:

> **Le ho vist*e*.** — "I saw them [f. pl.]."

That *-e* is a Latin adjective ending, still agreeing after two thousand years.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "ho parlato, hai parlato, ha parlato, abbiamo parlato, hanno parlato"
- the conservative *-t-* — "parla**t**o · French parlé"
- "Ho lavorato" ("I worked") — Ch. 5's verb

- the old meaning — "I **have** a thing **spoken**"

Before you move on

What two pieces make the *passato prossimo*? (**Avere** + the **past participle**.) What is *parlare*'s participle? (**Parlato** ← *-ātum*.) What did *ho parlato* originally mean? ("I **have** [a thing] **spoken**" — a **possessive**.) Why can the participle agree? (It was an **adjective** describing the object.) Next: the other Italian past, and where it still lives.

15.2 parlò — the past that depends where you are

Italian's other past tense. Whether it sounds normal or bookish depends on **which part of Italy you are standing in** — one of the clearest cases anywhere of geography deciding grammar.

You'll want to know: the remote past

	passato remoto	**passato prossimo**
he spoke	**parlò**	ha parlato
they spoke	**parlarono**	hanno parlato
I spoke	**parlai**	ho parlato

Note the final stress: *parl**ò***, with the accent written. Compare Chapter 12's numbers — Italian marks a stressed final vowel the same way.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

parlò ← Vulgar Latin ***parabolāvit**, the plain Latin perfect, handed straight down. Which makes it the **same tense** as:

language	**"he spoke"**
Italian	***parlò***
Spanish	*habló*
Portuguese	*falou*
French	*il parla*

One Latin ancestor, four descendants — and four different fates in daily life.

Why it's said this way

This is what makes Italian interesting here:

region	everyday past
Sicily, much of the south	**passato remoto** — *parlò* is normal speech
Tuscany	both, with a distinction of distance in time
North	**passato prossimo** almost always; *parlò* feels literary

So the "correct" answer changes as you travel. In the north the *passato remoto* has retreated to books, exactly as French's *passé simple* and German's *Präteritum* did. In the south it never left.

What you've built: three retreats and two holdouts

language	simple past	status in speech
French	*passé simple*	**gone** — books only
German	*Präteritum*	**retreating**, especially in the south
Italian	*passato remoto*	**split by region**
Spanish	*habló*	**alive** (though Spain is drifting toward *he hablado*)
Portuguese	*falou*	**alive**

Three languages let a "have" compound push the inherited past out of conversation; Italian is the one caught **mid-process**, with the old tense still holding half the country.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the pair — "parl**ò** … **ha** parlato"
- the sisters — "parlò · habló · falou · il parla"
- the geography — "in **Palermo** ordinary; in **Milano** literary"

Before you move on

What is the ancestor of *parlò*? (***parabolāvit**.) What decides whether it sounds normal or bookish? (**Where in Italy you are** — everyday in the south, literary in the north.) Which languages kept this tense fully alive? (**Spanish** and **Portuguese**.) Which lost it entirely from speech? (**French**.) Next chapter: the verbs that take *essere* instead of *avere*.

Chapter 16

Being, Going, and the Past with Essere

Modes: **voice** (2) **eyes** (2) **Hands-free start:** first 1 of 4 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say in Italian where I went, using essere as the auxiliary and making the participle agree with me.
>
> *Say sono stato and sono andato, switch to sono andata as a woman, run andato, andata, andati, andate, and set the whole set against avere's unchanging ho parlato.*

16.1 essere — "to be"

You have known one Italian "to be" since Chapter 2: **stare**, from Latin *stāre*, "to stand." Now meet **essere**, from Latin *esse*, "to be."

You'll want to know: the six forms

io **sono**	noi **siamo**
tu **sei**	voi **siete**
lui/lei **è**	loro **sono**

Italian normally drops the subject pronoun because the ending identifies the person: **Sono italiano** means "I am Italian." One collision needs care: **io sono** and **loro sono** are identical. Keep *loro* when context would not make "they" clear.

Grammar Lens: one accent and two words

È with the grave accent is the verb "is." Plain **e** is "and":

- Marco **è** italiano. — Marco **is** Italian.
- Marco **e** Anna. — Marco **and** Anna.

The two words sound different enough in careful speech, but the accent makes the contrast unmistakable on the page. Never drop it from the verb.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin	picture	Italian
esse	being or identity	**essere**
stāre	standing or state	**stare**

Italian kept both verbs. The next micro-lesson shows the surprising place where their histories overlap.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "sono, sei, è, siamo, siete, sono"
- "Marco è italiano" — then "Marco e Anna"
- "essere — be; stare — stand/state"

Twice through: "Sono, sei, è — siamo, siete, sono."

Before you move on

Give the six forms of *essere*. (**Sono, sei, è, siamo, siete, sono**.) What does the accent distinguish? (**È**, "is," from **e**, "and.") Which older verbs became *essere* and *stare*? (Latin ***esse*** and ***stāre***.) Next: why both verbs share **stato**.

16.2 essere → stato — a borrowed piece

Italian kept both Latin "be" verbs as **essere** and **stare**. Now look at the piece they unexpectedly share.

Grammar Lens: one participle for two verbs

verb	past participle
stare	**stato**
essere	**stato**

Essere's own participle did not survive. Latin *esse* never supplied a useful one, so Italian filled the empty slot with *stare*'s **stato**. A verb assembled from historically different roots is **suppletive**, like English *go / went*.
That shared piece creates a real ambiguity:

sono stato = "I have been" or "I have stayed"

Only the surrounding sentence tells you which verb is meant.

What you've built: three Romance solutions

The same Latin material took a different shape in each sister language:

language	result
Spanish	*ser* and *estar*: two verbs kept fully separate
French	*être*: one verb with old *stāre* pieces inside its forms
Italian	*essere* and *stare*: two verbs that share **stato**

Italian sits between the other two: less separated than Spanish, less fused than French. You do not need either sister language to use Italian; the comparison simply makes the borrowed piece visible.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "stare → stato"

- "essere → stato"
- "sono stato — I have been / I have stayed"

Twice through: "Two verbs, one **stato**."

Before you move on

What is *essere*'s participle? (**Stato**, borrowed from *stare*.) What can *sono stato* mean? ("I have **been**" or "I have **stayed**.") Which language keeps the two verbs fully separate? (**Spanish**.) Which fuses them most? (**French**.) Next: the two-stem verb **andare**, "to go."

16.3 andare — "to go," on two stems

Chapter 2 gave you **Come va?**, "How's it going?" The **va** inside it belongs to **andare**, "to go." Learn the whole verb before using it to build the past.

You'll want to know: the forms

io **vado**	noi **andiamo**
tu **vai**	voi **andate**
lui/lei **va**	loro **vanno**

Past participle: **andato**.

The table has a visible seam:

stem	forms	history
vad- / va-	vado, vai, va, **vanno**	Latin *vādere*, "to stride"
and-	andare, andiamo, andate, andato	origin disputed; perhaps *ambitāre*

Notice that **vanno** belongs with **vado**, not with *andiamo*. The split is not "singular versus plural." It is two old verbs patched into one modern paradigm — another case of **suppletion**, like *essere* borrowing *stare*'s **stato**.

Spanish shows the same kind of seam in *voy* beside *andar*. The comparison is a memory aid; the Italian forms above are the only ones you need here.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "vado, vai, va"
- "andiamo, andate, vanno"
- the infinitive and participle — "andare, andato"
- the Chapter 2 callback — "Come va?"

Twice through: "Vado, vai, va — andiamo, andate, vanno."

Before you move on

Give the six present forms. (**Vado, vai, va, andiamo, andate, vanno**.) Which plural form belongs to the *vad-* side? (**Vanno**.) What is the participle? (**Andato**.) Which familiar question already used *va*? (**Come va?**) Next: combine **essere + andato** and make the ending agree.

16.4 sono andato — the past built on essere

Chapter 15 built the past with *avere*: **ho parlato**. You now know the other auxiliary, **essere**, plus the participles **stato** and **andato**. Combine them, then watch the participle's ending change.

You'll want to know: start with stato

sono stato	I have been / stayed
sei stato	you have been / stayed
è stato	he has been / stayed
siamo stati	we have been / stayed

The plural **stati** is the first clue: with *essere*, the participle describes the subject and therefore agrees with it.

Grammar Lens: motion, change, and agreement

Many verbs of motion or change of state take **essere**: *andare* (go), *venire* (come), *arrivare* (arrive), *partire* (leave), *nascere* (be born), *morire* (die), *diventare* (become), plus *essere* and *stare*.
Use the four adjective endings you already know:

subject	sentence
Marco	Marco è **andato**.
Anna	Anna è **andata**.
the boys	I ragazzi sono **andati**.
the girls	Le ragazze sono **andate**.

A woman therefore says **sono andata**, not *sono andato*. The ending agrees with the **subject**, in gender and number: *-o, -a, -i, -e*.

Why it's said this way

The participle began as an adjective: **Anna è andata** was "Anna is gone-away," with *andata* describing Anna just as *stanca* ("tired") would. French keeps the same agreement (*elle est allée*); German uses a similar auxiliary split but no agreement (*sie ist gegangen*). The systems developed alongside one another, but only the Romance sisters preserve this adjective fossil visibly.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "sono stato, sei stato, siamo stati"
- "sono andato" — then, as a woman, "sono andata"
- "andato, andata, andati, andate"
- the contrast — "ho parlato; sono andato"

Before you move on

Which auxiliary do many motion and change verbs take? (**Essere**.) What does the participle agree with? (**The subject**.) Give all four endings. (***-o, -a, -i, -e***.) How does a woman say "I went"? (**Sono andata**.) Why does agreement survive? (The participle began as an

adjective.)

Chapter 17

Head and Hand

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (2) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 2 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name the head and the hand in Italian and get la mano right despite its -o ending.
>
> *Say la testa and la mano, pluralise to le mani, and explain the feminine article on an -o word through Latin's lost fourth declension.*

17.1 la testa — "the head"

French tells this word's story too. What is worth seeing here is how much **less** Italian did to it.

You'll want to know: the word

la testa — the head. Feminine.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin ***testa*** meant an **earthenware pot**, a shell, a shard. Roman soldiers' slang used it for the skull, and **across Gaul and Italy** the joke outlived the proper word *caput*. (Only there — Iberia kept *caput*, which is why Portuguese and Spanish still say *cabeça* and *cabeza*.)
Put the two descendants side by side:

Latin	***testa***
Italian	***testa*** — almost unchanged
French	***tête*** — *s* lost, vowels collapsed

This is the conservative-sister pattern this book keeps meeting. Chapter 11 had *acqua* against *eau*; Chapter 15 had *parlato* keeping the Latin *-t-* that *parlé* wore away. Italian holds its shape; French erodes.
Say them one after the other: *testa* … *tête*. Same word, ten centuries apart.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

French gave *caput* away almost entirely, keeping it only in *chef* and *chapitre*. Italian kept it as a **live, common word**:

il capo — the head (of an organisation), the boss, the chief.

So Italian has **both**: *testa* for the thing on your shoulders, *capo* for the person in charge. English borrowed the second one straight out of Italian — a *capo* in a crime family is exactly this word.
Also from *caput*: **capitale**, **capitolo** (chapter), and **capitano**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "la testa"
- "ho mal di testa" — "I have a headache"
- the erosion — "**testa** … **tête**"
- the pair — "la **testa** on your shoulders, il **capo** in charge"

Before you move on

Say "the head." (*La testa* — feminine.) What did *testa* mean in Latin? (An **earthenware pot** — soldiers' slang for the skull.) How does Italian compare with French here? (Italian kept it **almost unchanged** — the spelling is identical, the vowel opened; French wore it

down to *tête* — the conservative-sister pattern again, like *acqua/eau*.) What did Italian do with *caput*? (Kept it as ***il capo***, "boss, chief" — a live everyday word, where French kept it only outside the head-slot.) Next: the hand.

17.2 la mano — "the hand"

Italian nouns *tend* to announce their gender: **-o** is usually masculine, **-a** usually feminine. (Chapter 1 deliberately didn't give you that as a rule — it told you to learn each noun **with its article**, and this word is a good demonstration of why.)

You'll want to know: the word

la mano — the hand. **Feminine**, ending in **-o**. Plural: **le mani** — feminine, ending in **-i**.

Both halves are irregular. A masculine *-o* noun would pluralise in *-i* (*libro* → *libri*); a feminine noun usually ends *-a* and pluralises in *-e* (*casa* → *case*). *Mano* takes the feminine article and the masculine-looking endings.

Grammar Lens: five declensions

Italian inherited a system with **five declensions** — five families of endings — and flattened it to **three** productive classes: *-o/-i* (*libro/libri*), *-a/-e* (*casa/case*), and *-e/-i* (*notte/notti*, which Chapter 1 already gave you). *Manus* belonged to the Latin **fourth**, whose nouns ended in *-us* but could be **feminine**:

Latin		Italian
manus (4th decl., **fem.**)	→	*la mano*
manūs (plural)	→	*le mani*

When Italian dropped the fourth declension, *mano* was left with its old gender and an ending that now looks like it belongs to a different class. The word didn't change; **the system around it did.**

That is the general lesson, and it recurs constantly: an "irregular" word is usually a **regular word from a system that no longer exists**. (A few others survive the same way: *la radio*, *la foto*, *l'auto* — though those are short for *radiofonia*, *fotografia*, *automobile*, which is a different

reason for the same look.)

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin *manus* is inside many English words:

- *manual* and *manuscript*
- *manufacture* ("made by hand")
- *maintain* ("hold in the hand")

English took **manage** specifically from Italian ***maneggiare***, which meant to **handle a horse**. Every modern manager is, etymologically, working in a riding school.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "la mano, le mani"
- the breach — "**la** mano, feminine, ending in **-o**"
- the reason — "fourth declension, *manus*, feminine"
- "manage ← **maneggiare** — to handle a horse"

Before you move on

Say "the hand" and "the hands." (*La mano / le mani.*) What rule does it break? (The **tendency** that *-o* is masculine — *mano* is feminine.) Why? (Latin *manus* was **fourth declension**, whose nouns ended *-us* but could be feminine; Italian dropped that declension and left the word stranded.) What is the general lesson? (An **irregular** word is usually a **regular word from a lost system**.) Which English word came from Italian here, and what did it mean? (**Manage**, from *maneggiare*, to **handle a horse**.) Next: the rest of the body.

Chapter 18

Four Verbs of the Mind

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (4) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 4 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say in Italian that I think, understand, read and write, put a verb into each of the language's three families including the -isc- group, and build the past of reading and writing.
>
> *The chapter's last lesson closes the set: penso, capisco, leggo and scrivo run in one breath, one verb from each of Italian's three families, and the participles letto and scritto are rebuilt from lectum and scriptum by the same -ct- to -tt- law that made sette and otto.*

18.1 pensare — "to think," which began as "to weigh"

You already drive one Italian verb family: drop **-are**, add **-o / -i / -a**, and leave the pronoun unsaid — *parlo*, *lavoro*. This word costs you nothing new in grammar, and it buys a whole shelf of English.

Sounds you'll need

- `s-voiceless` — the *s* after *n* hisses, never buzzes: **pensare** = *pen-SA-reh*, not *pen-ZA-reh*.
- `r-tap` — one tapped *r*, the same tap as in *parlare*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

pensare comes from Latin **pēnsāre**, *"to weigh out carefully"* — itself from **pendere**, "to hang, to weigh." Roman thinking was done on a balance: you *weighed* a matter. English inherited both the scales and the thought:

- **pensive** — weighing something over.
- **ponder** — from *ponderāre*, "to weigh," off the same root through *pondus*, "a weight."
- **pension**, **compensate**, **expense**, **dispense** — all money *weighed out*, back when coin was measured rather than counted.
- **pendant**, **pending**, **suspend** — the hanging half of *pendere*.

Italian did something quietly remarkable with this one verb: it inherited it **twice**. *Pēnsāre* came down through ordinary speech, worn smooth, as **pesare**, "to weigh" — and it was later lifted a second time straight off the Latin page, unworn, as **pensare**, "to think." One Latin verb, two Italian words, two meanings. *Parlare* had no such double; it arrived once, from *parabolāre*.

Grammar Lens: the same three endings

Nothing new to learn — put *pensare* beside a verb you have:

person	***parlare***	***pensare***
(io)	parlo	**penso**
(tu)	parli	**pensi**
(lui/lei)	parla	**pensa**

To say what you are thinking *about*, Italian uses **a**, the same little word that carries *abito* ***a*** *Roma*:

Penso a Roma. — I'm thinking about Rome.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "pensare" — *pen-SA-reh*, hissing *s*

- "penso, pensi, pensa" — no pronoun spoken
- the trio — "parlo, lavoro, penso"
- "Penso a Roma."
- "pensare" then English "pensive, pension, compensate"

Before you move on

What did *pēnsāre* mean? (**To weigh out** — from *pendere*, "to hang, to weigh.") Name two English cousins. (*Pensive, pension, compensate, expense, ponder.*) Which two Italian words came from that one Latin verb, and how do they differ? (*Pesare*, "to weigh," worn down through speech; *pensare*, "to think," taken later off the page.) Give the three singular forms. (*Penso, pensi, pensa.*) And which Latin verb gave *parlare*? (*Parabolāre.*)

18.2 capire — "to understand," which began as "to grab"

Every verb you have so far ends in **-are**. This one ends in **-ire** and grows an extra syllable in the middle — a family Italian has and Spanish does not.

You'll want to know: the word

capire — to understand. **Capisco.** — I understand. (*ka-PEE-sko*) **Capisci?** — Do you understand? (*ka-PEE-shee*)

The second one is a question the way *Parli italiano?* was: nothing is added, the voice simply rises at the end.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

capire is built on Latin **capere**, *"to take hold of, to seize."* An Italian who understands you has **caught** what you said — the picture English draws with *I grasp it*, using a different verb for the same grabbing.
Capere is one of the busiest roots English owns: **capture**, **captive**, **capable**, **capacity**; **accept** (*ad-* toward + take), **receive** and **recipe** (*re-* back + take — a recipe is "take these things"), **except** ("taken

out"); **occupy**, **participate**, **anticipate**.

> **Careful — a look-alike that is not a relative.** Chapter 17 gave you **il capo**, "the boss," from *caput*, "head." *Caput* and *capere* are **two separate Latin words**. *Il capo* is a head; *capire* is a hand closing on something.

Grammar Lens: the -isc- family

Drop **-ire** to get *cap-*. A large group of *-ire* verbs push **-isc-** in front of the ending, but only where the stress falls on it:

person	***capire*** →
(io)	**capisco**
(tu)	**capisci**
(lui/lei)	**capisce**
(noi)	capiamo — no *-isc-*
(voi)	capite — no *-isc-*
(loro)	**capiscono**

That infix is a fossil. Latin had verbs in **-ēscere** meaning "to begin to." Italian lost the meaning, kept the syllable, and spread it over a whole class. **French did the same**: *finir* → *je finis*, *nous finissons*, where *-iss-* is this very *-isc-*. **Spanish did not** — its *-ir* verbs have no such infix.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "Capisco." then "Capisci?" — voice up at the end
- "capisco, capisci, capisce" then "capiamo, capite" — the infix drops out
- "Capisco l'italiano."
- the pair that is not a pair — "il **capo** ← *caput*; **capire** ← *capere*"
- "capire" then English "capture, capable, receive"

Before you move on

Say "I understand." (*Capisco.*) What did *capere* mean? (**To take hold of** — understanding as grasping.) Which two forms drop the *-isc-*, and where does that syllable come from? (*Capiamo* and *capite*; Latin *-ēscere*, "to begin to," the meaning gone and the sound kept.) Is *capire* related to *il capo*? (**No** — *capo* is from *caput*, "head.")

18.3 leggere — "to read," which began as gathering

Italian has exactly **three** verb families, sorted by how the infinitive ends: **-are**, **-ire**, and this one, **-ere**. With this word you have met all three, and the *-ere* family carries a sound trap in its own name.

Sounds you'll need

Italian *g* is **soft** before *e* and *i*, **hard** before *a*, *o* and *u* — and the spelling never warns you, because the letter does not change.

- `soft-g` — **leggere** = *LEDGE-eh-reh*. The *gg* before *e* is the *g* of English *judge*.
- `hard-g` — **leggo** = *LEG-go*. Before *o*, the same *gg* is the *g* of *go*.

This is the identical rule you met with *c* in **piacere** (*pya-CHEH-reh*, soft before *e*). One letter, two jobs, decided entirely by the vowel that follows it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

leggere comes from Latin **legere**, whose first meaning was *"to gather, to pick up"* — you gather olives, you gather firewood. From gathering came *picking out*, and from picking out came *picking the letters off a page*. That last step is the whole of "reading."
The gathering family is enormous in English:

- **legible**, **lecture**, **legend** ("things to be read"), **lesson**.
- **elect** ("pick out"), **select**, **collect**, **neglect** ("not to pick up"),

elegant (originally "choosy"), **intelligent** (*inter-* + *legere* — one who **picks between** things).

And Latin *legere* has a Greek cousin, **legein**, "to speak," which handed English every **-logy** and the word **dialogue**.

Grammar Lens: the -ere family, and where the stress lands

Drop **-ere**, add **-o / -i / -e**. Note that third form: the *-are* family ended in *-a* there, and this one ends in *-e*.

person	***capire***	***leggere***
(io)	capisco	**leggo**
(tu)	capisci	**leggi**
(lui/lei)	capisce	**legge**

One more thing your ear needs. *Parlare* and *capire* stress the last syllable but one — *par-LA-re*, *ca-PI-re*. Most *-ere* infinitives pull the stress **back onto the stem**: ***LEG-ge-re***.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "leggere" — *LEDGE-eh-reh*, stress on the front
- the flip — "leggere" (soft) then "leggo" (hard)
- "leggo, leggi, legge"
- the three families — "parlo, capisco, leggo"
- "leggere" then English "legible, lecture, legend, elect"

Before you move on

What did *legere* first mean? (**To gather** — then to pick out, then to read.) Name three English cousins. (*Legible, lecture, legend, elect, collect, intelligent.*) Why is the *gg* soft in *leggere* and hard in *leggo*? (The **following vowel** decides — soft before *e* and *i*, hard before *o*; the same rule as *c* in *piacere*.) Give the three singular forms. (*Leggo, leggi, legge.*) And where is the stress in the infinitive? (On the **stem** — *LEG-ge-re.*)

18.4 scrivere — "to write," which began as "to scratch"

Reading was gathering. Writing, in Latin, was **cutting** — and the verb is an *-ere* verb, so its present tense costs you nothing new. What it does buy you is a past tense, because this is where two old Latin endings resurface.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

scrivere comes from Latin **scrībere**, *"to scratch, to incise."* Before ink there was a stylus and a wax tablet, and writing was a cutting job. English took the root wholesale:

- **scribe**, **script**, **scripture**, **scribble**.
- **describe** ("write down"), **prescribe** ("write before"), **subscribe** ("write underneath" — which is what signing was), **postscript**.

Now weld it to a word you already own. Latin *manus*, "hand," gave you **la mano** — and the same *manus* sits in **manuscript** and in its Italian twin **manoscritto**: hand-written. That second half, *scritto*, is this verb.

Grammar Lens: the present, and two participles worth keeping

The present is the *-ere* pattern you already have: **scrivo, scrivi, scrive**. The past is where it gets interesting. Chapter 15 gave you the recipe: *ho* plus a participle, as in **ho parlato**. Regular *-are* verbs make that participle in *-ato*. These two do not:

verb	participle	with *ho*
leggere	**letto**	**ho letto** — I read
scrivere	**scritto**	**ho scritto** — I wrote

They look irregular and are nothing of the kind. Latin's participles were *lectum* and *scriptum*, and Italian applies to them the same sound-law that turned *septem* into **sette** and *octō* into **otto**: a consonant cluster with *-ct-* or *-pt-* collapses into a **doubled -tt-**. *Lectum* → *letto*. *Scriptum* → *scritto*. The rule you learned counting to ten is the rule that builds these.

What you've built this chapter

- **All three verb families**, one from each: **-are** (*penso*), **-ire** with the infix (*capisco*), **-ere** (*leggo*, *scrivo*).
- **Four minds' worth of Latin, and every one of them physical first**: *pēnsāre* to weigh, *capere* to seize, *legere* to gather, *scrībere* to scratch. Italian did not invent abstract words for thinking; it wore concrete ones smooth.
- **Two look-alikes kept apart**: *capire* ← *capere* (seize), *il capo* ← *caput* (head).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the four, in one run — "penso, capisco, leggo, scrivo"
- "ho parlato, ho letto, ho scritto"
- the sound-law — "*lectum* → letto, *scriptum* → scritto"
- "manoscritto" — *mano* plus *scritto*, written by hand

Twice through: "Penso, capisco, leggo, scrivo."

Before you move on

What did *scrībere* mean? (**To scratch, to incise** — stylus on wax.) Give the two participles and use them. (*Letto* and *scritto* — *ho letto*, *ho scritto*.) Why do both end in doubled *-tt-*? (Latin *lectum* and *scriptum*; *-ct-* and *-pt-* collapse to *-tt-*, exactly as in *sette* and *otto*.) Name the physical act behind each of this chapter's four verbs. (Weighing, seizing, gathering, scratching.)

Chapter 19

Taking, Asking, Helping — and Mi Piace

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (4) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 4 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say in Italian that I take, ask and help, and build a sentence with piacere the way Italian actually builds it — with the thing liked as the subject and me as the one it happens to.
>
> *The chapter's last lesson turns the set around: prendo, chiedo and aiuto in one run, then mi piace il vino read as the wine pleasing me, so the verb agrees with the thing and goes plural for le stagioni — and Chapter 3's one-word courtesy piacere is revealed as this verb's dictionary form.*

19.1 prendere — "to take," and the other Latin verb for grabbing

Chapter 18 closed with all three verb families in one breath — *penso, capisco, leggo, scrivo* — and with the point that each of those roots named a physical act before it named a mental one. Here is the fourth *-ere* verb, the one an Italian table asks of you, and its root closes that idea.

You'll want to know: the word

prendere — to take, to pick up, to catch.

Italian also uses it where English switches to *have*: what you take at a table is what you have. Every noun here is one you already own:

> **Prendo il pane.** — I'll have the bread. **Prendo l'acqua.** — I'll have the water. **Prendo il vino.** — I'll have the wine.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

prendere comes from Latin **prehendere**, *"to lay hold of, to seize."* English is full of it:

- **apprehend** (seize a person, or seize a meaning), **comprehend** ("seize together"), **reprehensible** ("to be caught out").
- **prehensile** — of a tail that grips.
- **prison** — from *prehēnsiō*, "a seizing"; **prey**, **prize** ("a thing taken"), and **surprise**, which is being *taken from above*.

Here is the pairing worth carrying away. Latin had **two** everyday verbs for seizing: *capere* and *prehendere*. Italian built **understanding** on the first — *capire*, catching what was said — and **taking** on the second. Two Latin hands, and only one of them is about objects.

Grammar Lens: the -ere present, and a participle that goes its own way

Nothing new in the present: **prendo, prendi, prende**.
The past participle is **preso**, and it does not double a *t*:

> **Ho preso il pane.** — I took the bread.

A different Latin cluster, doing a different thing. *Scrībere* was "to scratch" and its *scriptum* was the scratched thing; that *-pt-*, like the *-ct-* of *lectum*, collapses into **-tt-**. *Prehēnsum* had **-ns-**, and Italian drops the *n* for a plain **-s-**: *preso*. Two clusters, two outcomes, both regular.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "prendo, prendi, prende"

- "Prendo il pane. Prendo l'acqua. Prendo il vino."
- "Ho preso il pane." then "Ho scritto." — two clusters
- the two hands — "*capere* → capire; *prehendere* → prendere"
- the four physical roots — "weigh, seize, gather, scratch"

Before you move on

Ask for the wine. (*Prendo il vino.*) What did *prehendere* mean, and name two English cousins. (**To seize**; *apprehend, prehensile, prison, surprise.*) Which Latin seizing-verb gave *capire*, and which gave *prendere*? (*Capere*; *prehendere.*) Give the participle. (*Preso.*) Why is it not *pretto*, when *scrībere*'s participle is *scritto*? (Its cluster was **-ns-**, not the *-pt-* of *scriptum.*)

19.2 chiedere — "to ask," from a Latin verb meaning "to hunt for"

A third *-ere* verb, so the endings are free. This one comes with a spelling rule you have already met once, and a partner verb that looks like a blunt English one and is nothing of the kind.

Sounds you'll need

- `hard-ch` — **chiedere** = *KYEH-deh-reh.* Italian **ch** is always a hard *k*, never the *ch* of English *church.*

You met this in **mi chiamo** (*mee KYA-mo*). The job of that *h* is to keep the *c* hard in front of *e* and *i*, which would otherwise soften it. Italian spells the hardness in; English spells the softness in.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

chiedere comes from Latin **quaerere**, *"to seek, to look for, to hunt after."* Asking a question is going looking for an answer, and English kept the hunt everywhere:

- **query**, **question**, **quest** — the plain seeking words.
- **request**, **require**, **acquire**, **inquire**, **inquest**.

- **conquer** ("seek thoroughly"), and **exquisite**, something *sought out*.

The Italian shape is a long way from *quaerere*, and the road is worth hearing: Latin *qu-* before a stressed *e* went to **chi-**. Now use it on something you can already name:

> **Chiedo l'ora.** — I ask the time.

Grammar Lens: the present, and the second verb for asking

The present is the *-ere* pattern: **chiedo, chiedi, chiede**.
Italian has a second verb here, **domandare** — a plain *-are* verb: *domando, domandi, domanda*. Both mean "to ask". *Chiedere* is the everyday one and leans toward asking **for** a thing; *domandare* leans toward asking a **question**, and sounds a shade more formal.

> **Careful — a false friend.** *Domandare* is **not** English *demand*. It is from Latin **dēmandāre**: *dē-* plus **mandāre**, "to put into someone's hand" — and *mandāre* is *manus*, the hand you met as **la mano**, plus *dare*, "to give". English hardened that word into an order; Italian left it meaning simply "to ask". Same root, more English: **mandate**, **command**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "chiedere" — *KYEH-deh-reh*, hard *k*
- the pair — "mi chiamo … chiedere", the same hard *ch*
- "chiedo, chiedi, chiede"
- "Chiedo l'ora."
- "chiedere" then English "query, quest, require, exquisite"

Before you move on

How is Italian *ch* pronounced, and where have you seen it before? (Hard *k* — *mi chiamo*.) What did *quaerere* mean? (**To seek** — asking

as hunting for an answer.) Name three English cousins. (*Query, question, quest, require, acquire, exquisite.*) What is Italian's other verb for asking, and what does it **not** mean? (*Domandare* — **not** to demand; it is *dē* plus *mandāre*, "to put in the hand".) Which word you already know is buried in *mandāre*? (*Manus* — **la mano**.)

19.3 aiutare — "to help," and the word you shout

After three *-ere* verbs and the *-isc-* class that gave you *capisco*, back to the easy family: this one ends in **-are** and behaves exactly like *parlare*. What is unusual about it is the pile of vowels at the front, and the consonant Italian wore clean out of the middle.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

aiutare comes from Late Latin **adiūtāre**, a strengthened form of **adiuvāre**: **ad-**, "toward," plus **iuvāre**, "to help, to gladden." To help was to move toward someone with something good.
English took it through French and kept the *d*:

- **aid** — the direct descendant.
- **aide**, and **aide-de-camp**, "camp-helper."
- **adjutant** — an officer who assists; **adjuvant**, in medicine, something that helps a treatment along.

The three sisters split on that *d*, and this is the clearest sound-contrast in the chapter:

language	**"to help"**	**the Latin *d***
French	*aider*	kept, plainly
Spanish	*ayudar*	kept, softened around
Italian	***aiutare***	**gone entirely**

Italian's habit of dropping a *d* between vowels ran here to completion: *ad-iu-* became simply *ai-*. This is one of the places where Italian, usually the sister that keeps most, kept least.

Grammar Lens: the -are endings, and the shout

Drop *-are*, add the endings you have had since Chapter 5: **aiuto, aiuti, aiuta** — the run *parlo, penso, aiuto*, with *penso* keeping its hissing *s*. Say the *io* form slowly. Italian gives every written vowel its own moment: *a-i-U-to*, four sounds, stress on the *u*. Nothing is swallowed the way English would swallow it.
And there is a bonus in that form. Italian's noun for "help" is also **aiuto**, identical in spelling and sound to "I help" — so the cry heard in an Italian street, **"Aiuto!"**, is the same shape as the verb you have just conjugated.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "aiutare" — *ah-yoo-TA-reh*
- "aiuto, aiuti, aiuta" — four vowels in the first one
- the shout — "Aiuto!"
- the *-are* run — "parlo, penso, aiuto", hissing the *s* of *penso*
- the three sisters — "*aider*, *ayudar*, **aiutare**" — the *d* fading out
- "aiutare" then English "aid, aide-de-camp, adjutant"

Before you move on

What two Latin pieces make *adiūtāre*? (*Ad-*, "toward," plus *iuvāre*, "to help".) Name two English cousins. (*Aid, aide, adjutant, adjuvant.*) Which of the three sisters lost the *d*, and which kept it? (Italian lost it; French *aider* and Spanish *ayudar* kept it.) Give the three singular forms. (*Aiuto, aiuti, aiuta.*) Which of your *-are* verbs began as "to weigh"? (*Pensare.*) And what do you shout in the street? (**Aiuto!**)

19.4 mi piace — the verb that runs backwards

Chapter 3 closed an introduction with **piacere**, "a pleasure," from *placēre*. That courtesy is this verb's **dictionary form**. Here it goes to work — backwards.

You'll want to know: the word

> **mi piace** — I like it. Word for word: *to me it is pleasing.* **Mi piace il vino.** — I like the wine. (*mee PYA-cheh*)

The *c* is soft before *e*, as in *piacere*. And notice what is missing: any word for "I".

Grammar Lens: the thing you like is the subject

English makes the **liker** the subject: *I* like the wine. Italian has no such sentence — the wine does the pleasing. So **il vino** is the **subject**, hence *piace*, the ending you learned on *legge*; **mi** merely names who it pleases. The verb agrees with the **thing**, not with you:

what you mean	Italian
I like the wine	**Mi piace il vino**
I like the seasons	**Mi piacciono le stagioni**
I like reading	**Mi piace leggere**

One thing takes *piace*, many take **piacciono**, an infinitive counts as one — and in that third row *leggere*, the gathering verb, keeps its soft *gg*. To change *who* is pleased, change the word in front: **mi** (to me), **ti** (to you) — *Ti piace il vino?*
That *mi* is an old friend: **mi chiamo** is "I call *myself*", **mi piace** "it pleases *me*". One word, two jobs, neither "I".

> **Careful.** *Io piaccio il vino* does not exist. *Io piaccio* is real Italian — "**I** am pleasing" — but not what you wanted.

The shape is not unique to Italian. **Spanish**: *me gusta el vino*, on *gustāre*, "to taste." **French**, on this very *placēre*: *le vin me plaît*.

What you've built this chapter

- **prendere** ← *prehendere*, "seize" → apprehend, prison; at a table, *I'll have*.
- **chiedere** ← *quaerere*, "seek" → query, quest; hard *ch*; **domandare** is not *demand*.
- **aiutare** ← *adiūtāre* → aid, adjutant; the *d* dropped out.
- **The thread**: all four reach — for a thing, an answer, a person

— and *piacere* reaches back, from the thing to you. Hence the inversion. Chapter 18's *capire* reached too: *capere* meant to seize.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "Mi piace il vino." then "Mi piacciono le stagioni."
- "Mi piace leggere." and "Ti piace il vino?"
- "prendo, chiedo, aiuto", then "mi chiamo … mi piace"

Before you move on

In *mi piace il vino*, what is the subject? (**Il vino** — hence *piace.*) Say you like the seasons, and why the verb moved. (*Mi piacciono le stagioni* — many things.) Which Chapter 3 word is this verb's dictionary form? (*Piacere* ← *placēre.*) Name the roots under the chapter's other three verbs, and under *capire.* (*Prehendere*, *quaerere*, *adiūtāre*; *capere.*)

Chapter 20

Carrying, Buying, Waiting, Meeting

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (4) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 4 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say in Italian that I carry or bring something, buy it, wait for someone and meet them, run all four through the -are endings without a pronoun, and put them into the past with avere rather than essere.
>
> *The chapter's last lesson runs porto, compro, aspetto and incontro in one breath, then settles Chapter 16's open question by putting incontrare into the past: ho incontrato Marco and ho incontrato Anna, one unmoved participle, because only essere makes it agree — and it names the weld the other three share, a plain Latin verb behind com-, ad- and in-.*

20.1 portare — "to carry," and what an Italian does with a coat

Chapter 19 closed on a verb that ran backwards — **mi piace il vino**, where the wine does the pleasing and you are only the one it happens to. Here is a plain one: the *-are* endings of *aiuto, aiuti, aiuta*, doing a job English splits three ways.

You'll want to know: the word

portare — to carry, to bring, to take along.

> **Porto il pane.** — I bring the bread. **Porto l'acqua.** — I bring the water. **Porto il vino.** — I bring the wine.

Hold it against *prendere*, which was **seizing** — what you reach out and pick up. *Portare* is what happens next: the thing travels with you.

A second job catches learners out. This same verb also means **to wear**. Clothes are things you carry on your person, so *porto* covers a coat as readily as a loaf.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

portare comes from Latin **portāre**, *"to carry."* English is stacked with it:

- **portable**; **porter**, who carries your bags; **portfolio**, from Italian *portafoglio*, a leaf-carrier.
- **transport** ("carry across"), **export** ("carry out"), **import** ("carry in"), **report** ("carry back"), **support**, **deport**.
- **sport** — nobody sees this one coming. Old French **desporter** meant "to carry away": the mind, from serious matters. English wore *disport* down to **sport**.

Two cautions. The harbour **port** is a different Latin word, *portus*. And Latin *manus*, which gave you **la mano**, sits in the phrase *a mano*, "by hand": the hand is what does the carrying.

Grammar Lens: the endings, and a participle that behaves

Drop *-are*, add the usual: **porto, porti, porta**.
Chapter 15 gave you *ho* plus a participle; Chapters 18 and 19 handed you three that would not sit still. This one behaves:

verb	participle	with *ho*
portare	**portato**	**ho portato** — I brought
scrivere	*scritto*	*ho scritto* — I wrote
prendere	*preso*	*ho preso* — I took

Every regular *-are* participle ends in **-ato**. *Scritto* doubled its *t* because *scriptum* had a cluster to resolve; *preso* lost an *n* because *prehēnsum* had one to lose. *Portāre* had neither.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "porto, porti, porta"
- "Porto il pane. Porto l'acqua. Porto il vino."
- the pair — "Ho portato il pane." then "Ho preso il pane."
- "portare" then English "transport, export, import, porter"

Before you move on

Bring the wine. (*Porto il vino.*) What did *portāre* mean, and name three English cousins. (**To carry**; *transport, export, import, porter.*) Which English word for games is this verb in disguise? (*Sport*, from *desporter*, "to carry away".) Give the participle, and say why it is not doubled like *scritto*. (*Portato*; *portāre* had no cluster to collapse.) What else does *portare* mean? (**To wear**.)

20.2 comprare — "to buy," and the false trail to "compare"

A second *-are* verb, so the endings cost you nothing. What is new is the root, which sends nearly every English speaker down the wrong road on sight.

You'll want to know: the word

comprare — to buy.

Compro il pane. — I buy the bread. **Compro l'acqua.** — I buy the water. **Compro il vino.** — I buy the wine.

Italian keeps a longer form too, **comperare**. That is the older shape; speech squeezed the middle *e* out. Both are real, and the short one is what you hear.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

comprare comes from Latin **comparāre**, and the verb underneath it is **parāre**, *"to make ready, to procure."* Put **com-**, "together," in front and buying is **procuring**: bringing the thing and the price into one place. English took *parāre* over and over:

- **prepare** (*prae-*, "beforehand"), **repair** (*re-*, "back into readiness"), **separate** (*sē-*, "apart").
- **apparatus** and **apparel** — things made ready, for a machine and for a body.
- **emperor** and **empire**, through *imperāre*, which is *in-* plus this same *parāre*.
- Italian's own **parare**, "to ward off," borrowed as **parry** and standing in **parasol** and **parachute**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

English **compare** looks like a free gift here. It is not: the resemblance is exact and the connection is nil. Latin had **two** verbs spelled *comparāre*, built on unrelated words:

Latin verb	built on	where it went
comparāre (procure)	*parāre*, "make ready"	Italian **comprare**, to buy
comparāre (match)	*pār*, "equal"	English **compare**

The second is the *pār* of **par**, **parity**, **peer**, **pair** and **umpire**: setting two things side by side as equals. Buying is procuring, not weighing up. **Spanish** *comprar* and **Portuguese** *comprar* took the procuring-verb Italian took; **French** abandoned it and buys with *acheter*.

Grammar Lens: run them together

Chapter 5's exercise still works, with more to chew on. Take each *-are* verb through *io / tu / lui-lei*:

- **parlare**: parlo · parli · parla
- **portare**: porto · porti · porta

- **comprare**: compro · compri · compra

Same three endings, **-o / -i / -a**, and the pronoun stays dropped. The past is regular: **ho comprato il pane**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "compro, compri, compra"
- "Compro il pane. Compro il vino."
- the run — "parlo, porto, compro"
- "comprare" then English "prepare, repair, separate, apparatus"
- the warning — "*comprare* is procuring, **not** comparing"

Before you move on

Buy the bread. (*Compro il pane.*) Which Latin verb is inside *comprare*? (*Parāre* — **to make ready, to procure**.) Name three English cousins. (*Prepare, repair, separate, apparatus, emperor.*) Why is English *compare* **not** a relative? (Different Latin verb, same spelling, built on *pār*, "equal".) And which verb from the last lesson meant "to carry"? (*Portare.*)

20.3 aspettare — "to wait," which began as "to watch"

A third *-are* verb. Its endings are free, its root is one of the most productive in English, and the doubled *tt* in the middle is the work of a sound-law you learned while counting to ten.

You'll want to know: the word

aspettare — to wait, to wait **for**.

Aspetto. — I'm waiting. **Aspetto Anna.** — I'm waiting for Anna. **Aspetto Marco.** — I'm waiting for Marco.

Notice what the Italian is missing: any word meaning **for**. English cannot "wait somebody." Italian takes the person straight, as *porto il pane* takes the bread.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

aspettare comes from Latin **spectāre**, *"to watch, to gaze at"*, with **ad-**, "toward," welded on the front: to watch **toward** something. Waiting is watching for a thing to arrive, and the root runs through English:

- **spectator**, **spectacle**, **spectacles**, **spectrum**.
- **inspect** ("look into"), **respect** ("look back at"), **prospect** ("look forward"), **suspect** ("look from underneath"), **aspect**.
- **species** and **specimen**, from the plain verb *specere*, "to look."

Classical Latin's own word for waiting was **exspectāre** — *ex-* plus that same verb, "to watch out for" — and English took **that** one and made it **expect**. So *wait* and *expect* are one Latin verb wearing two prefixes, and Italian's single *aspettare* stands on the ground of both.

Grammar Lens: the doubled t, and the word that narrows the meaning

Present: **aspetto, aspetti, aspetta**. Past: **ho aspettato**, regular.
First that *tt*. Latin *spectāre* carries *-ct-*, and you know what Italian does with *-ct-*: *octō* became **otto**, *lectum* **letto**, *scriptum* **scritto**. The same law gives **aspettare**.
Second, the narrowing. Put **mi** in front and the verb stops meaning *wait* and starts meaning *expect*:

Italian	English
Aspetto.	I'm waiting.
Mi aspetto.	I expect.

That **mi** is a word you have met working elsewhere. In **mi chiamo** it turned the verb back on you — "I call *myself*." In **mi piace** it named the person a thing is pleasing *to*. Here it turns outward watching into inward reckoning.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "aspetto, aspetti, aspetta"
- "Aspetto Anna." — no word for *for*
- the pair — "Aspetto." then "Mi aspetto."
- the three uses of *mi* — "mi chiamo, mi piace, mi aspetto"
- the law — "*octō* → otto, *scriptum* → scritto, *spectāre* → aspettare"

Before you move on

Say you are waiting for Anna. (*Aspetto Anna* — nothing for "for".) What did *spectāre* mean, and name three English cousins. (**To watch**; *spectator, inspect, respect, prospect, species.*) Which prefix gave English *expect*, and which gave Italian *aspettare*? (*Ex-* and *ad-*.) Why the doubled *tt*, and what does **mi aspetto** mean? (*-ct-* collapses to *-tt-*, as in *otto*; **I expect**.)

20.4 incontrare — "to meet," which is literally "to come against"

The chapter's last *-are* verb. Its root is a preposition, its past settles a question Chapter 16 left open, and Italian keeps a second meeting-verb that shows its meaning only in the past.

You'll want to know: the word

incontrare — to meet, to run into. **incontro, incontri, incontra**.

Incontro Marco. — I meet Marco. **Incontro Anna.** — I meet Anna.

It has a partner English cannot keep apart from it, **conoscere**. *Incontrare* is the **event**, two people in one place; *conoscere* is the **acquaintance**, knowing a person.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

incontrare ← Late Latin **incontrā**: **in-** plus **contrā**, "against, opposite." To meet somebody is to come *against* them — not a fight, a facing. English borrowed it through French as **encounter**; bare *contrā* gave **contrary**, **contrast**, **counter**.
The best of the family is **country**: Vulgar Latin named a region *(terra) contrāta*, "the land lying opposite" — what is in front of you when you turn from the town.
conoscere is a different house: Latin **cognōscere**, *co-* plus *gnōscere*, "to come to know" → **cognition**, **recognize**, **incognito**, **notice**.

Grammar Lens: which past, and the one that means "met"

Chapter 16 split the past in two. Motion and change take **essere**, and the participle agrees: *Marco è andato*, *Anna è andata*, *sono stato*. All else takes **avere**, and nothing agrees.

> **Ho incontrato Marco.** — I met Marco. **Ho incontrato Anna.** — I met Anna.

Two people, one unmoved **incontrato** — because after *essere* the participle began as an adjective describing the subject, and after *avere* it describes nobody.
Now the hidden verb. Put **conoscere** in the past and its job changes:

> **Ho conosciuto Marco.** — I met Marco — for the first time.

What you've built this chapter

- **portare** ← *portāre*, "carry" → transport, export, porter, *sport*; it also means to **wear**, and *portato* is the regular participle.
- **comprare** ← *comparāre* on *parāre*, "procure" → prepare, repair, apparatus — and **not** the *comparāre* behind English *compare*.
- **aspettare** ← *ad-* + *spectāre*, "watch toward" → spectator, inspect, prospect; *ex-* on that verb gave *expect*, and **mi aspetto** says it.
- **incontrare** ← *in-* + *contrā*, "against" → encounter, contrary,

country.

- **The thread**: four verbs, one set of *-are* endings — *porto, compro, aspetto, incontro* — and three of them weld a small word onto a plain Latin verb: *com-*, *ad-*, *in-*. Italian inherited the welds without the seams.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "Incontro Marco. Ho incontrato Anna."
- the contrast — "Anna è andata" beside "Ho incontrato Anna"
- the first meeting — "Ho conosciuto Marco."
- the chapter — "porto, compro, aspetto, incontro"

Before you move on

Meet Marco. (*Incontro Marco.*) What two pieces make *incontrā*, and which English word for a place is *contrā* in disguise? (*In-* plus *contrā*; *country.*) Why *ho incontrato Anna* and not *sono incontrata*? (Not motion, so *avere.*) Name the roots under the chapter's other three verbs. (*Portāre*, *parāre*, *spectāre.*)

Chapter 21

Two Ways to Play, and Two Verbs That Bend

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (3) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 3 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can tell apart the two Italian verbs English calls play — giocare for a game, suonare for an instrument — say that I obtain something and that I answer someone, and explain the silent h of giochi and the doubled tt of ottenere.
>
> *The chapter's last lesson gathers gioco, suono, ottengo and rispondo, then reads risposto against preso: prehēnsum lost its n and gave preso, so respōnsum ought to have given risposo, and instead the verb joins the small -sto band with chiedere's chiesto — Chapter 17's rule that an irregular form is a regular one from a system you can no longer see.*

21.1 giocare and suonare — the two verbs English calls "play"

English has one word for playing a game and playing an instrument. Italian has two unrelated ones, and picking the wrong one is the most recognisable mistake an English speaker makes.

You'll want to know: two words, not one

> **giocare** — to play a game, a sport, a match. **suonare** — to play an instrument; also, to ring or to sound.

The line is what you are doing, not the English word:

what you are doing	Italian
playing a game	**giocare**
playing an instrument	**suonare**
a bell ringing	**suona**

Chapter 19 gave you the frame — *mi piace* plus a dictionary form, as in *mi piace leggere*:

> **Mi piace giocare.** — I like playing. **Mi piace suonare.** — I like playing music.

A grammatical tell too: *giocare* wants **a** before the game's name, while *suonare* takes the instrument bare.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Two roots, never near each other.
giocare ← Latin **iocārī**, "to jest," from **iocus**, *a joke*. English took *iocus* as **joke**, and through French as **jeopardy** — *jeu parti*, "a divided game." Italian still calls a game **il gioco**.
suonare ← Latin **sonāre**, "to sound," from **sonus**, *a noise*. That is English **sound** itself, plus **sonata** (from Italian: a thing *sounded*, against a *cantata*, a thing sung), **resonate**, **unison**, **dissonant**. And **counterpoint** — Italian *contrappunto*, note against note — carries the *contrā* of the last lesson's *incontrare* into music.
The split is no rule to memorise: two unrelated Latin words, covered in English by a single native verb.

Grammar Lens: the h that keeps a c hard

Both are ordinary *-are* verbs — until the *tu* form of the first one.

> **gioco, giochi, gioca · suono, suoni, suona**

Gioco is *JO-ko*: the **g** is soft before *i*, the **c** hard before *o*. Now change the ending to *-i*: written *gioci*, that *c* would soften to *JO-chee*. Italian will not let a consonant shift because an ending did, so it spells in an **h**: **giochi**, *JO-kee*.
You have met that letter doing opposite work:

where	what the h does
chiedere, *mi chiamo*, *giochi*	keeps a **c** hard before *e* and *i*
hanno against *anno*	separates two identical sounds in writing

The second row is Chapter 14: **hanno venti anni**, where *hanno* ("they have") and *anno* ("year," ← *annus*, the *annus* of *annual*) sound identical and only the silent *h* tells them apart.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "gioco, giochi, gioca" · "suono, suoni, suona"
- "Mi piace giocare." then "Mi piace suonare."
- the hard-c family — "chiedere, mi chiamo, giochi"

Before you move on

Which verb plays a match, and which an instrument? (*Giocare*; *suonare*.) Give each root and an English cousin. (*Iocus* → *joke*, *jeopardy*; *sonus* → *sound*, *sonata*.) Say you like playing music. (*Mi piace suonare*.) Give the *tu* form of *giocare* and the letter's two jobs. (*Giochi* — the *h* holds the *c* hard, as in *chiedere*; in *hanno* it separates the word from *anno*.)

21.2 ottenere — "to get," and a b that flattened into a t

The last lesson was about **doing** — playing a game, playing an instrument. This one is about **having**. English *get* means almost anything; Italian has nothing of the sort, and for the sense that matters, **coming to have** a thing, the verb is this one.

You'll want to know: the word

ottenere — to get, to obtain, to come to have.

Line it up with what you have. *Prendere* **seizes** a thing, *portare* **carries** it. *Ottenere* **obtains** it: it was not lying there for the taking.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ottenere comes from Latin **obtinēre**: **ob-**, "toward, up against," plus **tenēre**, *"to hold."* To obtain is to get a hold on something:

- **obtain** — the compound borrowed whole.
- **tenacious**, **tenant** and **tenure** (a holding), **tenet** ("he holds"), **tenor**.
- **contain**, **retain**, **maintain** — which Chapter 17 gave you as "hold in the hand."

English stacked prefixes on *tenēre* exactly as it stacked them on the last chapter's *portāre*: one Latin verb, a rack of prefixes.
Tenēre also explains Chapter 14, where Italian counted years with *avere*: **Ho venti anni**. **Spanish** says *tengo veinte años*, **Portuguese** *tenho vinte anos*, and both verbs are this same *tenēre*. Where Italian **has** its years, Spain and Portugal **hold** theirs — and English and German simply **are** twenty.

Grammar Lens: bt lands on tt, and a stem that bends

Obtinēre has a **b** and a **t** side by side, and Italian will not say them that way. It does to *-bt-* what it did to *-ct-* and *-pt-*: the first consonant flattens into the second.

Latin	Italian
octō	**otto**
scriptum	**scritto**
obtinēre	**ottenere**

The forms bend under stress: **ottengo, ottieni, ottiene**. A **g** surfaces in the *io* form; the stem's *e* breaks into *ie* in the other two. Where *giocare* spelled in an **h** to hold a consonant still, this verb lets the vowel move instead. The past is ordinary — **ottenuto**, regular the way *portato* was, so **ho ottenuto**. That *-ngo* is the shape Spanish shows in *tengo*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "ottengo, ottieni, ottiene" then "Ho ottenuto."
- the three — "prendo, porto, ottengo"
- the clusters — "*octō* → otto, *scriptum* → scritto, *obtinēre* → ottenere"
- the years — "Ho venti anni" beside Spanish "tengo veinte años"

Before you move on

What two pieces make *obtinēre*, and name three English cousins? (*Ob-* plus *tenēre*; *obtain, tenacious, tenant, maintain.*) Why *ottenere* and not *obtenere*? (*-bt-* flattens to *-tt-*, as *-ct-* did in *otto.*) Give the singular forms and the participle, and the Chapter 20 participle it behaves like. (*Ottengo, ottieni, ottiene*; *ottenuto*, like *portato.*) Which Latin verb do Spanish *tengo* and Portuguese *tenho* come from? (*Tenēre.*)

21.3 rispondere — "to answer," which is "to pledge back"

Back to the *-ere* family: the present costs nothing new. Chapter 19 taught you to ask; this is the other half, and its root is about a promise, not speech.

You'll want to know: the word

rispondere — to answer. On the *-ere* pattern of *leggo* and *chiedo*: **rispondo, rispondi, risponde**.

One catch, mirroring one you own. *Aspettare* takes its object bare where English needs a preposition — *aspetto Anna*, "I wait **for** Anna." *Rispondere* demands an **a** where English wants none:

Rispondo a Marco. — I answer Marco.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

rispondere ← Latin **respondēre**: **re-**, "back," plus **spondēre**, *"to pledge solemnly."* An answer was a pledge given in return, and the English family is unexpectedly personal:

- **respond**, **response**, **responsible**; **correspond**, "pledge together"; **despond**.
- **sponsor** ← *spōnsor*, who pledges for you.
- **spouse** ← *spōnsus*, *spōnsa*, "the promised one," and **espouse**.

Chiedere, with its hard *ch*, came from *quaerere*, "to seek." The asking-verb is a **hunt**; the answering-verb a **promise**.

Grammar Lens: the participle, and which past a story uses

The participle is **risposto** — **ho risposto**, "I answered." Latin's was *respōnsum*, with the same *-ns-* as *prehēnsum*, and *prehēnsum* gave you **preso**: the *n* dropped, a plain *-s-* left. So this should be *risposo*. It is not. **Risposto** joins a small *-ere* band ending in **-sto**, with *chiedere*'s **chiesto** — Chapter 17's principle over *la mano*: an "irregular" form is a regular one from a system you can no longer see.
Chapter 15's other past, the **passato remoto** — *parlò*, *parlarono* — is the one a story uses, because answering is what people do in stories. In Sicily and the south it is ordinary speech; in the north it retreated into books, as French shelved its *passé simple*.

What you've built this chapter

- **giocare** ← *iocus*, "a jest" → joke, jeopardy — a game. **suonare** ← *sonus*, "a noise" → sound, sonata, unison — an instrument. English merged them; Italian never did.
- **ottenere** ← *ob-* + *tenēre*, "hold toward" → obtain, tenant, retain, with *-bt-* landing where *-ct-* and *-pt-* did, and a bending stem: *ottengo, ottieni, ottiene.*
- **rispondere** ← *re-* + *spondēre*, "pledge back" → respond, sponsor, spouse.
- **The thread**: Chapter 19 ended on verbs that **reach**, and on

piacere, which reaches back from the thing to you. This chapter closes it: *ottenere* is the reach that lands, *rispondere* the return journey, *giocare* a reach for nothing at all.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "rispondo, rispondi, risponde"
- "Aspetto Anna", then "Rispondo a Marco"
- "Ho risposto." beside "Ho chiesto."
- "gioco, suono, ottengo, rispondo"

Before you move on

Answer Marco. (*Rispondo a Marco.*) What did *spondēre* mean, and name three English cousins. (**To pledge**; *respond, sponsor, spouse.*) Give the participle and say why it is not *risposo*. (*Risposto* — the *-sto* band with *chiesto*, not the *-so* of *preso*.) Which Latin verbs sit under *chiedere* and *ottenere*, and where is the *passato remoto* everyday speech? (*Quaerere*; *tenēre*; **the south**.)

Chapter 22

Coffee, Tea, Milk, and Sugar

Modes: **voice** (2) **eyes** (2) **Hands-free start:** none of the 4 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can ask for coffee, tea, milk and sugar in Italian, and tell which of the four were borrowed and which was inherited.
>
> *The chapter's last lesson gathers il caffè, il tè, il latte and lo zucchero, meets lo on a real noun for the first time since Chapter 1 stated the rule, and sorts all four by history: caffè from Turkish, tè from Chinese, zucchero from Arabic by a different road than caffè, and latte alone never borrowed at all.*

22.1 il caffè — coffee, and the word half of Europe borrowed together

Chapter 11 gave you the table's bread and wine. Here is the fourth thing you would ask for at an Italian bar, and its history runs east, not to Rome.

You'll want to know: the word

il caffè — coffee. Masculine.

Prendo il caffè. — I'll have the coffee. **Mi piace il caffè.** — I like coffee.

Order plainly at an Italian bar and what arrives by default is a small, strong shot — what English speakers call "espresso." Italian needs no separate word for it: that shot **is** what "coffee" defaults to.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

caffè ← Ottoman Turkish **kahve** ← Arabic **qahwa**. Venice's merchants brought the drink and the word together in the 1600s, and from Italian — or in step with it — the word spread across the continent almost unchanged: English **coffee**, French **café**, German **Kaffee**, Spanish **café**. Say *italiano* enough times and you already knew Italian could carry a foreign word whole (Chapter 5's *italiano* itself, from Oscan, was no different) — this one simply came from further east.

Grammar Lens: a plural that refuses to change

Regular nouns change in the plural: *il pane* would become *i pani* if it had one. **Caffè** does not. Italian never pluralises a noun stressed on its own final, accented syllable — **il caffè, i caffè**, identical. You met the same written accent, for the same reason, on *così* in Chapter 2.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "il caffè"
- "Prendo il caffè." then "Mi piace il caffè."
- "i caffè" — unchanged in the plural
- "caffè" then English "coffee, café, Kaffee" — one word, four languages

Before you move on

Order a coffee. (*Prendo il caffè.*) Which language gave Italian *caffè*, and which language gave that language the word? (**Turkish** *kahve*, from **Arabic** *qahwa.*) What happens to *caffè* in the plural, and why? (**Nothing** — nouns stressed on a final accented syllable don't change.) Name two other European languages with nearly the same word. (*Café*, *Kaffee*, among others.)

22.2 il tè — tea, and the map hiding inside its name

A second drink, and a second word with a long trip behind it — this one didn't come from Arabic at all. It came from China, by sea.

You'll want to know: the word

il tè — tea. Masculine, and — like *caffè* — unchanged in the plural: **il tè, i tè**.

Prendo il tè. — I'll have the tea.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

tè ← Hokkien Chinese **tê**, the word spoken in the port of Amoy (Xiamen), where Dutch traders loaded it onto ships bound for Europe as **thee**. Italian, English **tea**, French **thé** and German **Tee** all sailed in on that same cargo.
Mandarin and Cantonese say the same word differently: **chá**. That form travelled overland along the Silk Road, and every language on that road inherited it instead — Persian **chāy**, Russian **chai**, Hindi **chai**, Arabic **shāy**. One plant, two pronunciations, and the boundary between "tea-languages" and "chai-languages" on a modern map is a fossil of a sixteenth-century shipping route.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "il tè"
- "Prendo il tè."
- "tè" then English "tea, thé, Tee" — the sea route
- the contrast — "tè" against "chai" — one word, two roads

Before you move on

Order a tea. (*Prendo il tè.*) Which Chinese dialect gave Italian *tè*, and by which route did it travel? (**Hokkien** *tê*, **by sea**, via Dutch.) Which languages instead say some form of *chai*, and how did they get it? (Persian, Russian, Hindi, Arabic — **overland**, from Mandarin/Cantonese *chá*.) What does *tè* do in the plural? (**Nothing** — same rule as *caffè*.)

22.3 il latte — milk, the drink that never left home

Caffè travelled from Arabic through Turkish. *Tè* travelled from Chinese by sea. This drink went nowhere at all — it has said the same thing in this family since before there was an Italy.

You'll want to know: the word

il latte — milk. Masculine, doubled *-tt-* held clearly: *LAHT-teh*.

Prendo il latte. — I'll have the milk.

Ordinary plural rules apply here — *latte* is the mass-noun kind of word you rarely pluralise, unlike *caffè* and *tè*'s stressed-vowel exception.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

latte ← Latin **lac**, genitive **lactis**. English took the genitive stem straight into science: **lactic**, **lactate**, **lactose**, **lactation**. It even hides in a vegetable: **lettuce** ← Latin **lactuca**, "the milky plant," named for the white sap that beads on a cut stem.
Set the three drinks side by side: *caffè* came from Arabic, *tè* from Chinese, *latte* from nowhere further than Rome's own Latin. Not every word on an Italian table travelled — some simply stayed.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "il latte" — hold the doubled *tt*
- "Prendo il latte."

- "latte" then English "lactic, lactose" — and, unexpectedly, "lettuce"
- the three drinks — "caffè, tè, latte" — Arabic, Chinese, Latin

Before you move on

Order milk. (*Prendo il latte.*) What Latin word gave Italian *latte*, and name an English cousin. (*Lac, lactis → lactic/lactose.*) Which common English vegetable name hides the same root? (**Lettuce**, from *lactuca*, "the milky plant.") Of *caffè*, *tè* and *latte*, which one never left Latin? (*Latte.*)

22.4 lo zucchero — sugar, and a rule Chapter 1 only promised

The last word for the table, **lo zucchero** — *bianco*, Chapter 13's white — and the first noun in this whole track to actually need the article Chapter 1 only described.

You'll want to know: the word

lo zucchero — sugar. Masculine, and **lo**, not *il*.

Lo zucchero è bianco. — The sugar is white.

Chapter 1 told you Italian keeps a second masculine "the," **lo**, for "tricky clusters" — and gave you only invented examples, *lo studente, lo zio*. Here is the rule meeting a real word: *zucchero* starts with **z**, one of the sounds *lo* exists for.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

zucchero ← Arabic **sukkar**, itself from Persian **shakar**, from Sanskrit **śarkarā**, "gravel, grit" — sugar crystals looked like fine gravel to everyone who first met them refined. English **sugar** carries the same Arabic word, but by a different road: through Old French **sucre**, not through Turkish like *caffè*. Two words in this chapter, both ultimately Arabic, arrived in Italian by two separate routes at two different centuries.

Grammar Lens: *lo*, finally on a real word

Lo appears before **z**, before **s** plus another consonant, before **gn**, **ps**, **x** and **y**, and before **i** plus a vowel. *Il* covers everything else. Nothing here is new — Chapter 1 stated exactly this — but *zucchero* is the first noun in this track where you actually have to reach for **lo** instead of *il*, rather than take the rule on faith.

What you've built this chapter

- **caffè** ← Turkish *kahve* ← Arabic *qahwa* — borrowed, sixteenth century, through Venice, and still invariable in the plural: *i caffè*.
- **tè** ← Chinese *tê* — borrowed, by sea, through Dutch.
- **zucchero** ← Arabic *sukkar* — borrowed, through Old French's cousin *sucre*.
- **latte** ← Latin *lac* — never borrowed at all.
- **The thread**: three loanwords and one inherited word, side by side on the same table. A word's history has nothing to do with how ordinary it feels to say.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "lo zucchero" — *lo*, not *il*
- "Lo zucchero è bianco."
- the four — "il caffè, il tè, il latte, lo zucchero"
- "zucchero" then English "sugar" — same Arabic word, different road

Before you move on

Give "sugar" with its article. (**Lo zucchero**.) Why *lo* and not *il*? (It starts with **z**, one of Chapter 1's *lo*-triggers.) Trace *zucchero* back three languages. (Arabic *sukkar* ← Persian *shakar* ← Sanskrit *śarkarā*.) Which English word came by a different road from the same Arabic source? (**Sugar**, through Old French *sucre*.) Of the four words this chapter taught, which one was never borrowed? (*Latte*.)

Chapter 23

Friends, Family, and a Name

Modes: **voice** (3) **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** none of the 4 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can introduce a friend, name a family as a whole, ask for someone's name with the word itself, and say 'person' the way Italian always does.
>
> *The chapter's last lesson gathers l'amico/l'amica, la famiglia, il nome and la persona, closing on the one noun taught so far whose grammatical gender never tracks the sex of whoever it names.*

23.1 l'amico, l'amica — friend, from loving

Chapter 22 left you at the table with *il caffè, il tè, il latte* and *lo zucchero* — and its **lo**, remember, was for a cluster like *z-*. Chapter 10 gave you your family. Introducing someone rarely stops there — you also name the people you've chosen, not just the people you were born to.

You'll want to know: the word

l'amico — friend (male). **l'amica** — friend (female).

Both take **l'**, the elided form — you already met it on *l'acqua* — because both start with a vowel. The gender still exists, it just doesn't show on the article here; it shows the moment another word has to agree with it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

amico/amica ← Latin **amicus/amica**, built directly on **amāre**, "to love." English kept the whole family: **amiable**, **amicable**, **amity**. And its opposite is hiding in plain sight — English **enemy** ← Latin **inimicus**, literally *in-* ("not") + *amicus*: an enemy is, word for word, a **not-friend**.

Grammar Lens: when *lo/la* becomes *l'*

Chapter 1 gave you *il/la/lo*. Both singular articles before a vowel — masculine **lo** and feminine **la** alike — shorten to **l'**, dropping their own vowel into the next one:

article	**before a consonant**	**before a vowel**
masculine	il amico *(wrong)* / lo amico *(wrong)*	**l'amico**
feminine	la amica *(wrong)*	**l'amica**

L'acqua (Chapter 11) was your first example; *l'amico* and *l'amica* are the second and third, and the first place you can see the SAME elided form covering two different genders side by side.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "l'amico, l'amica"
- the elision — "lo + amico → l'amico", "la + amica → l'amica"
- "amico" then English "amiable, amicable" — and "enemy", the opposite

Before you move on

Give "friend" for a man and for a woman. (*L'amico, l'amica.*) Which Latin verb sits under both, and name two English cousins. (*Amāre*, "to love" → *amiable, amicable.*) Which English word is built from the same root with a "not" in front? (**Enemy**, ← *inimicus.*) Why do both words take *l'* instead of *lo* or *la*? (Both start with a **vowel** — the article elides.)

23.2 la famiglia — the word for the whole group

Chapter 10 named the individuals — *padre*, *madre*, *fratello*, *sorella*. Here is the word for all of them together, and unlike last lesson's friend, this one never crossed a border.

You'll want to know: the word

la famiglia — the family. Feminine, regular **-a**.

Said plainly, of any family — yours, someone else's, a stranger's on the street: **la famiglia**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

famiglia ← Latin **familia**. Its oldest sense was broader than "blood relatives": a Roman *familia* was the whole household under one head, including servants — from **famulus**, "servant, slave." The word narrowed over the centuries to the sense you'd give it today. English took it with barely a letter changed: **family**, **familiar** (originally "belonging to the household"), **familial**.
Set it beside last lesson's *amico*: *amico* came from **loving** someone; *famiglia* came from **serving** in the same house. Two very different starting points landed on two words for people close to you.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "la famiglia"
- "famiglia" then English "family, familiar, familial"
- the pair — "amico ← loving", "famiglia ← serving"

Before you move on

Give "the family." (**La famiglia**.) What did a Latin *familia* originally include, beyond blood relatives? (**Servants** — the whole household.) Which word is *familia* built on, and what did it mean? (*Famulus*, "servant.") Of this chapter's two words, which comes from **loving** someone and which from **serving** in the same house? (*Amico* ←

loving; *famiglia* ← serving.)

23.3 il nome — the word Chapter 3 talked around

Mi chiamo…, Come ti chiami? — Chapter 3 taught you to exchange names without ever once saying the word "name." Here it is, on its own.

You'll want to know: the word

il nome — the name. Masculine.

Il nome è italiano. — The name is Italian.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

nome ← Latin **nomen**, genitive **nominis**. The English family from this one root is enormous: **noun** (grammar's word for a naming-word), **nominate** ("to name for a role"), **nominal**, **pronoun** ("standing in for a noun"), **synonym** and **anonymous** (Greek-flavoured cousins, *syn-* "together" and *an-* "without," both riding on the same ancient root as *nomen*), and **renown** — "re-named," made famous enough to be named again and again.

Why it's said this way

Mi chiamo Marco does not mean "my name is Marco" word for word — it means "**I call myself** Marco." *Come ti chiami?* is "**how do you call yourself**?" Italian's everyday way of exchanging names uses the verb *chiamarsi*, "to call oneself," from beginning to end, and *nome* never has to appear. It surfaces instead on forms, in third-person talk about someone, and now, in your own vocabulary.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "il nome"
- "Il nome è italiano."

- "nome" then English "noun, nominate, pronoun, anonymous, renown"
- "famiglia" then English "family, familiar" — last lesson's inherited word
- the contrast — "mi chiamo" (I call myself) beside "il nome" (the name)

Before you move on

Give "the name." (**Il nome**.) What does *mi chiamo Marco* literally say, word for word? ("**I call myself** Marco" — not "my name is.") Name three English cousins of Latin *nomen*. (*Noun, nominate, pronoun, anonymous, renown* — any three.) Which verb carries the whole *Come ti chiami?* exchange, and does it ever use *nome*? (*Chiamarsi*, "to call oneself" — **no**.)

23.4 la persona — the word that outranks its own referent's sex

One more word for talking about people in general — *l'amico* (elided, Chapter 23's own rule), *la famiglia*, *il nome* (the word *mi chiamo* always talked around), and now the broadest of all — and it breaks the gender rule you've trusted since Chapter 1 in a way none of the others do.

You'll want to know: the word

la persona — the person. Feminine — **always**, whoever is meant.

Even when the person being described is a man, Italian still says *la persona*. The article and the ending agree with the WORD's own gender, which is fixed; they say nothing about the sex of whoever the word points at. You've half-met this before: Chapter 17's *la mano* is feminine by an accident of Latin declension, not because hands are somehow female. *Persona* is a different kind of exception — a word for a person that simply never changes its own gender to match its referent.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

persona was a Latin word for a **theatrical mask** — the kind worn on a Roman stage. Its origin past that point is genuinely disputed: an old story claims it comes from *per-* ("through") plus *sonāre* ("to sound"), a mask built to project an actor's voice. Most modern scholars now treat that as folk etymology and favour an Etruscan word, *phersu*, borrowed into Latin before it ever meant "a human being." From mask to role to the person underneath the role: English kept the whole arc — **person**, **personal**, **personnel**, **impersonate** ("to put on someone else's mask"), and **parson**, an English clergyman's title from the same word by a well-worn sound-shift.

Grammar Lens: the word outranks the world

Every noun you've tagged with gender so far — *il padre*, *la madre*, *il fratello*, *la sorella* — has tracked something real: fathers are grammatically masculine because they are actually male. *Persona* does not. It is grammatically feminine **by category**, full stop, the way a ship is sometimes called "she" in English regardless of anything real about ships. Grammatical gender and the sex of a living referent are two different systems that usually agree and occasionally, as here, simply don't.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "la persona" — always feminine
- "persona" then English "person, personal, personnel, parson"
- "nome" then its Latin root "nomen" once more
- the four together — "l'amico, la famiglia, il nome, la persona"

Before you move on

Give "the person." (**La persona**.) What did Latin *persona* originally mean, and what is its further origin? (A **theatrical mask**; disputed — likely **Etruscan** *phersu*, not the old *per-* + *sonāre* story.) Name three English cousins. (*Person, personal, personnel, parson, impersonate* — any three.) Why is *la persona* always feminine, even

describing a man? (Grammatical gender is a fixed **category** of the word, not a report on the referent's sex.)

Chapter 24

Heart, Eyes, Ears, and Mouth

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (4) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 4 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name my heart, eyes, ears and mouth in Italian, and trace the sound-law that built two of them.
>
> *The chapter's last lesson gathers il cuore, l'occhio, l'orecchio and la bocca, the set Chapter 17's la mano lesson promised, and closes on bocca's history as slang for 'cheek' that replaced Latin's real word for mouth.*

24.1 il cuore — the heart, and a promise Chapter 17 made

Chapter 23 closed on *la persona* — always feminine, however general. Chapter 17 closed with "next: the rest of the body," after *la testa* and *la mano*. Here it begins — asking how someone is can reach past *bene* and *così così* into the body itself.

You'll want to know: the word

il cuore — the heart. Masculine.

Unlike *la mano*, this one is **not** an exception: *cuore* ends in **-e**, and Chapter 17 already told you *-e* nouns can be either gender — you simply learn each one with its article. *La notte* was feminine *-e*; *il cuore* is masculine *-e*. Both regular, in their own way.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

cuore ← Latin **cor**, genitive **cordis**. The English family is large and mostly hidden: **cordial** (warm, "from the heart"), **courage** (via Old French *corage*, "heart" as the seat of nerve), **accord** and **concord** ("hearts together"), **discord** ("hearts apart"), and **record** — *re-* plus *cor*, "to call back to the heart," because before writing, you kept things **by heart**.
La mano's lesson ended by pointing forward to "the rest of the body." This chapter and the next are that promise, paid: heart, eyes, ears and mouth here, nose, stomach and throat after. None of them repeats *mano*'s trick of an irregular gender — that was Latin's lost fourth declension doing something unique to *manus* — but each has its own root worth digging up.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "il cuore"
- "cuore" then English "cordial, courage, accord, record"
- the contrast — "il cuore" (masc. -e) beside "la notte" (fem. -e)

Before you move on

Give "the heart." (**Il cuore**.) What Latin word is inside it, and name three English cousins. (*Cor, cordis → cordial, courage, accord, discord, record* — any three.) Why isn't *cuore* an exception the way *mano* was? (**-e** nouns can be either gender; *cuore* is a regular masculine example, *notte* a regular feminine one.) What did Chapter 17 promise that this chapter starts paying off? (**The rest of the body.**)

24.2 l'occhio — the eye, worn down from three syllables to one

After the heart, the eye — and a word that changed shape more violently on its way from Latin than almost anything else in this

book. Every *persona* has one, whatever *il nome* on their door says.

You'll want to know: the word

l'occhio — the eye. Masculine, elided **l'** before its own vowel — the same move you learned on *l'amico*.

Said *OHK-kyoh*: a hard **c**, then a fast **y**-glide into *o*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

occhio ← Latin **oculus**, three clean syllables: *OH-ku-lus*. Italian's own sound laws crushed it: the unstressed middle vowel dropped (*oculus* → *oc'lus*), and the leftover cluster **-c'l-** regularly hardens into **-cchi-** — a general Italian sound law, not a one-word accident. What arrived is one syllable where Latin had three. English, working from the untouched original, kept **ocular**, **oculist**, **binoculars** ("two-eyed" instruments), and **monocle** ("one eye").

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "l'occhio" — *OHK-kyoh*
- the collapse — "oculus → oc'lus → occhio"
- "occhio" then English "ocular, oculist, binoculars, monocle"
- the pair so far — "il cuore, l'occhio" — the body-word set Chapter 17 promised

Before you move on

Give "the eye." (**L'occhio**.) What Latin word did it come from, and how many syllables did that word have? (*Oculus* — **three**.) What sound-change turned the middle cluster into *-cchi-*? (The unstressed vowel dropped, leaving *-c'l-*, which hardened to **-cchi-**.) Name three English cousins. (*Ocular, oculist, binoculars, monocle* — any three.) Why is *la persona* always feminine, and does Italian's everyday name-exchange ever use *il nome*? (Grammatical gender is a fixed category,

independent of the referent's sex; and no — *chiamarsi* carries the whole exchange.)

24.3 l'orecchio — the ear, and a "little ear" that grew up

Last lesson's collapse — three Latin syllables crushed into one — was not a one-time accident. Here it is again, on the very next body part in the set Chapter 17 promised.

You'll want to know: the word

l'orecchio — the ear. Masculine, elided **l'**.

Said *oh-REHK-kyoh* — the same hard-**c**-plus-glide shape as *occhio*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

orecchio ← Latin **auricula**, literally "**little ear**" — a diminutive of **auris**, "ear." *Auricula* lost its unstressed vowel the same way *oculus* did, and the same **-c'l-** → **-cchi-** law finished the job: one regular sound-change, applied to two different body-part words, and both times a longer Latin word became a shorter Italian one. English kept *auris* and *auricula* nearly whole in its own vocabulary: **aural** ("of the ear") and **auricle** (an ear-shaped part of the heart or the outer ear itself) — so, unusually, this lesson's English cousins name a piece of *last* lesson's word.

Grammar Lens: one law, twice

Latin	dropped a vowel	Italian
oculus	*oc'lus*	**occhio**
auricula	*auric'la*	**orecchio**

Once you can name the pattern — an unstressed vowel falls out, the leftover **-c(u)l-** hardens into **-cchi-** — you can predict how other words of this shape landed, even ones this book never teaches directly. (One more example, just to hear it work: Latin *genuculum*, "little knee," gives Italian *ginocchio*.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "l'orecchio" — *oh-REHK-kyoh*
- "orecchio" then English "aural, auricle"
- the pair — "occhio, orecchio" — one sound-law, twice

Before you move on

Give "the ear." (**L'orecchio**.) What Latin word did it come from, and what did that word literally mean? (*Auricula*, "**little ear**," from *auris*.) What sound-law built both *occhio* and *orecchio*? (An unstressed vowel drops, and the leftover **-c(u)l-** hardens to **-cchi-**.) Name an English cousin of *auris*. (*Aural* or *auricle*.)

24.4 la bocca — the mouth, a word that used to mean "cheek"

Heart, eyes, ears — the last two built by the same *-c'l-* → *-cchi-* law — and now the mouth, which closes this chapter with the strangest history of the four: the word you're about to learn is not even the Latin word for "mouth."

You'll want to know: the word

la bocca — the mouth. Feminine, doubled **-cc-**: *BOHK-ka*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Classical Latin's real word for "mouth" was **os**, genitive **oris** — you already have its cousin in English **oral**, **oration**, **oracle**. But everyday spoken Latin reached instead for **bucca**, a slang word that actually meant "**cheek**," puffed out and vivid, the way English might say "gob" or "kisser" for "mouth." The slang won: *bucca* became the ordinary word for "mouth" across nearly the whole Romance family — Italian **bocca**, Spanish **boca**, Portuguese **boca**, French **bouche** — while *os/oris* survived only in learned English borrowings, never as an everyday Romance word for the body part itself. French *bouche* gave English two

rarer cousins: **debouch** (troops "mouthing out" of a narrow pass into open ground) and **embouchure** (where a musician's mouth meets an instrument).

What you've built this chapter

Il cuore, l'occhio, l'orecchio, la bocca — heart, eyes, ears, mouth, the set Chapter 17 promised when *la mano*'s lesson signed off. Ask *Come stai?* (Chapter 2), answer *bene* or *così così*, and now you can point to more than your hand while you do it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "la bocca" — *BOHK-ka*
- "bocca" then English "debouch, embouchure" — both via French *bouche*
- the four — "il cuore, l'occhio, l'orecchio, la bocca"

Before you move on

Give "the mouth." (**La bocca**.) What was Latin's actual word for "mouth," and what did *bucca* originally mean? (*Os/oris*; *bucca* meant **cheek**.) Name two rare English cousins that came through French *bouche*. (*Debouch, embouchure.*) Which four body words has this chapter now taught, in order? (*Cuore, occhio, orecchio, bocca.*)

Chapter 25

Nose, Stomach, and Throat

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (3) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 3 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name my nose, stomach and throat in Italian, closing the body-word set Chapter 17 opened.
>
> *The chapter's last lesson gathers il naso, lo stomaco and la gola, closing the seven-word body set begun in Chapter 24, and lays out the five different kinds of word-history behind those seven words in one place.*

25.1 il naso — the nose, and a flower named after it

Three body words left. This one has a straightforward Latin root and a genuinely surprising English cousin waiting at the end of it.

You'll want to know: the word

il naso — the nose. Masculine.

Said *NAH-zoh*: the single **s** sits between two vowels, which Italian voices — the same sound as the **s** in English *rose*, not the one in *sink*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

naso ← Latin **nasus**. English kept it directly in **nasal**, and built one word by welding it to Old English: **nostril**, "nose" plus *thyrl*, "hole" — a nose-hole. The real surprise is a garden flower: **nasturtium** ←

nasus plus *torquēre*, "to twist" — literally a **nose-twister**, for the sharp, peppery smell that makes a nose wrinkle.

Grammar Lens: when a single *s* sounds like *z*

Italian's traps list already warned you that **z** can be *ts* or *dz*. **S** has its own split: a single **s** between two vowels is usually **voiced**, like English *z* — *naso*, *così* (Chapter 2). A **doubled** *ss* stays voiceless, the plain *s* of English *sink*. One letter, two sounds, and position is what decides.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "il naso" — *NAH-zoh*, voiced *s*
- "naso" then English "nasal, nostril, nasturtium"
- the voiced-*s* pair — "naso, così"

Before you move on

Give "the nose." (**Il naso**.) What garden flower hides *nasus* plus a Latin verb for "to twist," and what does it literally mean? (**Nasturtium** — "nose-twister.") What English word welds *nasus* to an Old English word for "hole"? (**Nostril**.) How does a single *s* between two vowels sound in Italian? (**Voiced**, like English *z* — as in *naso* or *così*.)

25.2 lo stomaco — the stomach, on loan from Greek

Every body word so far went straight back to Latin, and the last one taught you that a single *s* between vowels is voiced. This one takes a detour through Greek instead — and needs Chapter 22's other article again.

You'll want to know: the word

lo stomaco — the stomach. Masculine, and **lo**, not *il* — it starts with **s** plus a consonant, exactly the cluster Chapter 22's *lo zucchero* trained you to expect *lo* before.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

stomaco ← Latin **stomachus** ← Greek **stómakhos**, "throat, gullet, stomach," itself built on **stóma**, "mouth." Latin borrowed the Greek medical vocabulary wholesale in antiquity, long before Italian existed, so *stomaco* only *feels* as native as *cuore* or *naso* — underneath, it travelled through one more language than they did. English took the same word by the same route: **stomach**, spelled almost as Latin left it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "lo stomaco" — *lo*, not *il*
- "stomaco" then English "stomach" — nearly the same word
- the *lo* pair — "lo zucchero, lo stomaco"

Before you move on

Give "the stomach." (**Lo stomaco**.) Why *lo* and not *il*? (It starts with **s** plus a consonant.) Which language did *stomaco* pass through before it reached Latin? (**Greek** — *stómakhos*, from *stóma*, "mouth.") Is *stomaco*'s root older or younger, inside Latin, than *naso*'s? (**Younger** — borrowed from Greek, where *nasus* was native Latin all along.)

25.3 la gola — the throat, closing the body

The last body word, and the piece that connects the mouth to the stomach — heart, eyes, ears, mouth, nose, stomach, and now the throat between them.

You'll want to know: the word

la gola — the throat. Feminine, regular **-a**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

gola ← Latin **gula**, "throat." English kept it almost whole in **gullet**, by way of Old French. A tempting further step: Latin also had a verb **gluttire**, "to gulp down," the direct ancestor of English **glutton**. Several dictionaries propose that *gluttire* and *gula* ultimately share the same ancient root for swallowing — plausible, and worth knowing, but treated here as **proposed**, not settled, exactly as this book flagged *persona*'s Etruscan origin as the leading guess rather than a certainty.

What you've built this chapter

Two chapters, seven words: **cuore, occhio, orecchio, bocca, naso, stomaco, gola** — heart, eyes, ears, mouth, nose, stomach, throat. Three came straight from Latin roots (*cuore*, *naso*, *gola*); two collapsed under the same Italian sound-law (*occhio*, *orecchio*); one is slang that outlived the "proper" word it replaced (*bocca*); one detoured through Greek before it ever reached Latin (*stomaco*). Seven words, five different kinds of history, all landing on one *Come stai?*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "la gola"
- "gola" then English "gullet" — and, cautiously, "glutton"
- the full seven — "cuore, occhio, orecchio, bocca, naso, stomaco, gola"

Before you move on

Give "the throat." (**La gola**.) What Latin word gave Italian *gola*, and its clear English cousin? (*Gula* → **gullet**.) Which English word is *proposed*, not certain, to share the same root? (**Glutton**, from *gluttire*.) Name the seven body words this pair of chapters taught, in order. (*Cuore, occhio, orecchio, bocca, naso, stomaco, gola.*)

Italian pronunciation — a reference

Not to be read before the lessons — each lesson gives the sounds its word needs. This page just gathers them. Italian is gloriously **phonetic**: once you know these rules, you can read almost any word aloud correctly.

The traps for an English speaker

- **Every letter is sounded**, and vowels are pure: *a* (ah), *e* (eh), *i* (ee), *o* (oh), *u* (oo) — never the English glide.
- **c** and **g** are soft (*ch*, *j*) before *e/i* (*ciao*, *giorno*), hard (*k*, *g*) before *a/o/u* (*casa*, *gatto*). **ch/gh** force the hard sound (*chi* = "kee").
- **gli** = the *lli* of *million*; **gn** = the *ny* of *canyon*; **sc** before *e/i* = *sh*.
- **z** = *ts* or *dz* (*grazie* = "GRAH-tsyeh").
- **Double consonants are held longer** and change meaning: *notte* (night) vs. *note* (notes).
- **h** is always silent — it exists only to harden *c/g*.

Stress

Most words stress the *second-to-last* syllable (*giOR-no*). When the stress falls on the last syllable it is written with an accent (*città*, *cosí*, *caffè*).

Italian in the Romance family

Italian, Spanish, and French are all worn-down Latin. Italian stayed closest to the parent, so its *-ct-* became *-tt-* (*notte*) where Spanish went *-ch-* (*noche*)

and French *-it-* (*nuit*); and it kept final vowels (*giorno*, *notte*) that French dropped. The lessons draw these contrasts as they arise.

Glossary

This glossary collects every word and phrase taught in the book. Pronunciation appears when it differs from the written form; chapter numbers show where each entry is introduced.

a domani
see you tomorrow (literally "to tomorrow")
Introduced in Chapter 4.

a più tardi
see you later (literally "to more late")
Introduced in Chapter 4.

a presto
see you soon (literally "to soon")
Introduced in Chapter 4.

abitare
to live / to dwell (a second -are verb — same pattern)
Introduced in Chapter 5.

aiutare
to help — and the shout an Italian street uses for it
Introduced in Chapter 19.

andare
to go — one verb built from two historical stems
Introduced in Chapter 16.

arrivederci
goodbye (literally "until we see each other again")
Introduced in Chapter 4.

aspettare
to wait — and, with one small word in front, to expect
Introduced in Chapter 20.

avere
to have — and Italy's only silent letter, which exists purely to prevent confusion
Introduced in Chapter 14.

buongiorno
good day / good morning
Introduced in Chapter 1.

buono / buon
good (adjective)
Introduced in Chapter 1.

capire
to understand — literally "to take hold of", and Italian's third conjugation with its own infix
Introduced in Chapter 18.

chiedere
to ask — from Latin "to seek", with a second verb beside it that is a false friend in English
Introduced in Chapter 19.

ciao
hi / bye (informal)
Introduced in Chapter 1.

come
how / like, as
Introduced in Chapter 2.

Come sta?
formal "how are you?"
Introduced in Chapter 2.

Come stai?
how are you? (informal)
Introduced in Chapter 2.

Come ti chiami?
what's your name? (informal); formal Come si chiama?
Introduced in Chapter 3.

Come va?
how is it going?
Introduced in Chapter 2.

comprare
to buy — from procuring, not from comparing, however much the two look alike
Introduced in Chapter 20.

così così
so-so (literally "thus, thus" — "this way, that way")
Introduced in Chapter 2.

diciassette — venti
17–20 — Italian flips the order at 17: the ten jumps to the FRONT
Introduced in Chapter 12.

essere
to be — the other Italian "to be"
Introduced in Chapter 16.

giocare, suonare
the two verbs English calls "play" — one for games, one for instruments, and no relation between them
Introduced in Chapter 21.

giorno
day (masculine)
Introduced in Chapter 1.

grazie
thank you
Introduced in Chapter 1.

ho parlato
the passato prossimo — avere plus a participle, the everyday Italian past
Introduced in Chapter 15.

ho venti anni
age — Italian HAS its years, and the last lesson's silent h finally earns its keep
Introduced in Chapter 14.

i mesi
the months — the Roman calendar, barely worn down
Introduced in Chapter 9.

il / la / lo
the (masculine / feminine)
Introduced in Chapter 1.

il caffè
coffee — the pan-European word Italy took from an Ottoman drink
Introduced in Chapter 22.

il cuore
heart — the root behind courage, accord, and record
Introduced in Chapter 24.

il fratello, la sorella
brother and sister — frater/soror plus Italy's favourite little-endings
Introduced in Chapter 10.

il latte
milk — the one drink here Italian never had to borrow
Introduced in Chapter 22.

il naso
nose — twisted by its own name
Introduced in Chapter 25.

il nome
name — the word Chapter 3 never actually needed
Introduced in Chapter 23.

il padre, la madre
father and mother — Italian keeps them closest to Latin pater/mater
Introduced in Chapter 10.

il pane
bread — closest to Latin pānis, and the "companion" who shares it
Introduced in Chapter 11.

il tè
tea — the sea-route word, where "chai" is the overland one
Introduced in Chapter 22.

incontrare
to meet — literally "to come against", with a second meeting-verb hiding inside a past tense
Introduced in Chapter 20.

io
I (first-person subject pronoun)
Introduced in Chapter 3.

l'acqua, il vino
water and wine — acqua kept Latin's whole aqua, where French wore it to eau
Introduced in Chapter 11.

l'amico, l'amica
friend (m./f.) — from loving, and the reason "enemy" is its own opposite
Introduced in Chapter 23.

l'occhio
eye — three Latin syllables worn down to one
Introduced in Chapter 24.

l'orecchio
ear — the same sound-law as the eye, one lesson later
Introduced in Chapter 24.

la bocca
mouth — not Latin's real word for it, but the one that won
Introduced in Chapter 24.

la famiglia
family — the one word here Italian never had to borrow
Introduced in Chapter 23.

la gola
throat — and possibly the swallow at the bottom of "glutton"
Introduced in Chapter 25.

la mano
the hand — the noun that breaks Italian's own gender rule
Introduced in Chapter 17.

la persona
person — always feminine, no matter who it is
Introduced in Chapter 23.

la testa
the head — the pot-word, kept in its original shape
Introduced in Chapter 17.

lavorare
to work (a third -are verb — and the "labour" road, not the "torture" one)
Introduced in Chapter 5.

le stagioni
the seasons — and "primavera," the first green
Introduced in Chapter 9.

leggere
to read — literally "to gather up", and Italian's third and last verb family
Introduced in Chapter 18.

lo stomaco
stomach — the one body word that stopped in Greece before it reached Rome
Introduced in Chapter 25.

lo zucchero
sugar — Arabic again, but by the French road this time, not the Turkish one
Introduced in Chapter 22.

lunedì, martedì, mercoledì, giovedì, venerdì
the weekdays (Monday–Friday) — the planets, with the day-word at the end
Introduced in Chapter 7.

mezzogiorno, mezzanotte
noon and midnight — "mid-day" and "mid-night"
Introduced in Chapter 8.

mi chiamo
my name is (literally "I call myself")
Introduced in Chapter 3.

mi piace
I like it — built backwards, as "it is pleasing to me"
Introduced in Chapter 19.

nero, bianco
black and white — nero straight from Latin, bianco borrowed from the Germanic invaders
Introduced in Chapter 13.

notte / buonanotte
night / good night
Introduced in Chapter 1.

ora
hour / o'clock — telling the time with the feminine article
Introduced in Chapter 8.

ottenere
to get, to obtain — a holding-verb, and a b that flattened into a t
Introduced in Chapter 21.

parlare
to speak / to talk (your first regular -are verb)
Introduced in Chapter 5.

parlò
the passato remoto — the simple past, alive in the south and in books
Introduced in Chapter 15.

Parlo italiano
"I speak Italian" — your first full sentence (italiano = Italian)
Introduced in Chapter 5.

pensare
to think — literally "to weigh out", and a fourth verb on the -are pattern
Introduced in Chapter 18.

piacere
pleased to meet you (literally "a pleasure")
Introduced in Chapter 3.

portare
to carry, to bring — and, without warning, to wear
Introduced in Chapter 20.

prego
you're welcome (and please, go ahead, after you)
Introduced in Chapter 2.

prendere
to take — and, at a table, to have; Italian's other verb of seizing
Introduced in Chapter 19.

rispondere
to answer — literally "to pledge back", the other half of Chapter 19's asking
Introduced in Chapter 21.

rosso, blu
red and blue — an ancient inherited root, a second Germanic loan, and the Arabic blue of the Azzurri
Introduced in Chapter 13.

sabato, domenica
the weekend (Saturday, Sunday) — Sabbath and the Lord's day
Introduced in Chapter 7.

scrivere
to write — literally "to scratch", and the chapter's four minds in one run
Introduced in Chapter 18.

sei, sette, otto, nove, dieci
the numbers 6–10 (and the months hidden in them)
Introduced in Chapter 6.

sera / buonasera
evening / good evening
Introduced in Chapter 1.

sono andato
the passato prossimo built on essere, with the participle agreeing with the subject
Introduced in Chapter 16.

stare
to be (a state — how you're doing); literally "to stay/stand"
Introduced in Chapter 2.

undici — sedici
11–16 — Italian keeps Latin's fusions so clearly you can still read the "ten" in them
Introduced in Chapter 12.

uno, due, tre, quattro, cinque
the numbers 1–5
Introduced in Chapter 6.

Review Questions

Try these without looking ahead. Every prompt comes from the same canonical lesson data as its chapter. Answers begin in the next section.

Chapter 3

3.1 *Practice — introducing yourself in Italian*
Why can Italian usually omit io?

Answer Key

The first response is the canonical display answer. When a question accepts other authored forms, they appear underneath.

Chapter 3

3.1 *Practice — introducing yourself in Italian*
Answer: the verb ending says who
Also accepted: the verb ending identifies the subject; the verb ending carries the subject

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Look up an English meaning, a dedicated language topic, or a chapter topic. Each linked reference opens the chapter where the material is introduced; the focus labels name only explicitly typed lesson sections.

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to meet — literally "to come against", with a second meeting-verb hiding inside a past tense *incontrare*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 20, p. 113
to read — literally "to gather up", and Italian's third and last verb family *leggere*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 18, p. 97
to speak / to talk (your first regular -are verb) *parlare*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 5, p. 33
to take — and, at a table, to have; Italian's other verb of seizing *prendere*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 19, p. 105
to think — literally "to weigh out", and a fourth verb on the -are pattern *pensare*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 18, p. 97

to understand — literally "to take hold of", and Italian's third conjugation with its own infix *capire*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 18, p. 97
to wait — and, with one small word in front, to expect *aspettare*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 20, p. 113
to work (a third -are verb — and the "labour" road, not the "torture" one) *lavorare*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 5, p. 33
to write — literally "to scratch", and the chapter's four minds in one run *scrivere*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 18, p. 97
Two Italian Pasts
chapter topic; Chapter 15, p. 79
Two Ways to Play, and Two Verbs That Bend
chapter topic; Chapter 21, p. 123

W

water and wine — acqua kept Latin's whole aqua, where French wore it to eau *l'acqua, il vino*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 11, p. 63
what's your name? (informal); formal Come si chiama? *Come ti chiami?*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 3, p. 17

Y

you're welcome (and please, go ahead, after you) *prego*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 7